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The Record Survives

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*“Witnessing matters. Because if you look at something
and then record that you looked, you’ve done something
to it — something that changes what it is.”*

I

Act One: The Silent Cage

Chapter One: The Kingdom of Neglect

The attic held its breath.

Not silence — silence was something clean, something chosen. This was the collected exhalation of years: stale burlap, decomposing wood, the sweet rot of whatever fruit had died in the corner and never been found. The air clung to Adil's throat like a second skin. He had stopped noticing it the way you stop noticing the colour of your own bedroom walls — it was simply the texture of existing here, in this narrow corridor between the rice sacks and the skeletal dresser, where the world's claim on him briefly loosened.

He was nine years old. He had been hiding for most of it.

The dresser smelled of mothballs and something older — a wet, organic smell that predated the furniture itself, as if the wood remembered being a tree in a place that rained. Adil had pressed his back against it so many times the grain had begun to feel familiar against his spine: the small knot at shoulder height, the crack running diagonally where the wood had warped in summer, the rough edge of the bottom drawer that protruded by two precise millimetres. He knew this dresser the way cartographers know coastlines. Not because he loved it. Because it was reliable. In a life shaped by the unpredictable, reliability was the only form of love he understood.

The rice sacks were his mountains. Hessian-wrapped, floor-to-ceiling stacks that had accumulated over years in the manner of all household things that have no place to go — not thrown away because they might be needed, not used because there was always more. They leaned at angles, pressed against each other for support, and smelled of the damp inside the burlap

and the faintly fermented sweetness of grain beginning its slow, inevitable return to earth. Adil had mapped them with his hands in the dark so many times he could have drawn them from memory. There was a gap between the third and fourth stack on the right — two fingers wide — where, if you pressed your eye against it, you could see the dust motes turning lazy circles in the single beam of light that entered through the high, grime-streaked window. He called this the Observatory. He had not told anyone about the Observatory because there was no one he could tell.

The rats were the only other tenants of consequence.

He heard them before he saw them — the quicksilver scratching of claws on wood, the soft percussion of small bodies navigating the underside of the floorboards. They had their own geography up here, their own routes and rituals, and Adil respected this with the pragmatic neutrality of someone who has learned that any living thing that does not intend you harm is, at minimum, neutral company. Occasionally, one would venture close enough that he felt the hot, dry flicker of fur against his bare ankle. The first few times this had happened, his whole body had seized — a full-body startle response that sent adrenaline flooding up through his chest and into his throat, the almost-sound of a scream hitting the back of his teeth before he swallowed it down. He had trained himself past this, the way you train yourself past any reflex — through repetition, through will, through the slow calcification of instincts into something quieter and more durable. Now, when a rat pressed briefly against his foot, he would brush it away with a motion barely large enough to qualify as a motion. The displacement of air. The memory of a gesture.

In the attic, movement was currency, and Adil had learned to be frugal.

What he could not train himself past was the sound of the slippers.

The house had a particular acoustic — marble floors downstairs that reported every footfall with a clarity that bordered on accusatory, and then the wood of the stairs, each tread its own distinct pitch depending on where your foot landed, the outside edge of the third step singing high and sharp, the middle of the seventh giving a low, hollow complaint. Adil had memorised this score the way musicians memorise sonatas — involuntarily, through

sheer exposure, the notes filing themselves into memory whether he wanted them there or not.

The slippers were the particular threat. Rubber soles on marble: a soft, compressed sound that his mother made when she moved through the house in the particular quality of anger that was quiet rather than loud. The loud anger was easier. The loud anger announced itself, gave you the physics of the situation, the trajectory, the probable duration. The quiet anger was the one that appeared at the doors. That pressed against the base of the attic stairs and stood there, breathing.

Shh-clack. Shh-clack.

The moment the sound pattern changed — the moment it shifted from the arbitrary movement of a person going about a house to the directed purposefulness of a person coming somewhere — Adil's body made its own decision without consulting him. The shivering started in the long bones, femur and tibia, as if the marrow itself had turned to cold water, and radiated outward through muscle, through skin, arriving at the surface as a barely perceptible vibration that he fought with every muscle he owned. He pressed his back into the dresser. He pressed his hands flat against his knees. He made himself into a right angle of compressed stillness.

He understood the physics with a precision that would have impressed any physicist who specialised in the mechanics of fear: a single sharp intake of breath, the groan of a floorboard under a shifted hip, the rustle of hessian. Any of these things could create a small doubt. The small doubt was the precursor to the footstep on the first stair. And the footstep on the first stair was the end of the world.

So he did not breathe sharply. He did not shift his hip. He sat with his hands wrapped so tightly around his knees that the blood left his knuckles, and he held the earth still by the sheer force of not moving. A small boy anchoring himself in space against the possibility of being found.

Time in the attic passed differently from time anywhere else.

Below, time was a series of demands: be here, do this, recite this, sit still, answer the question, finish the food, say it again, say it louder, why won't you say it? Time was measured by the distance between one expectation and the

next. Up here, time was the slow migration of a single bar of light across the floorboards — the way the afternoon sun entered at the high, grime-filmed window at a steep angle and then relaxed, degree by degree, until the yellow deepened through amber into a bruised, tired orange, and then at last began its quiet retreat into the corners like something ashamed.

Adil tracked this light with the attention he gave nothing else.

The dust motes inside it were his companions in the truest sense: they moved without agenda, without the specific directed quality that characterised all the movement in his life. They turned in small, unhurried circles, catching the light for a fraction of a second before turning away from it, driven by air currents too subtle to feel, and there was something in the randomness of their motion that Adil found unbearably calming. He had begun to give them narratives. The large one near the window was returning from somewhere long. The small cluster near the top of the rice sacks had never been anywhere at all and had no opinion about this. The single one drifting near his knee was making a decision.

He knew this was not true. He was not insane; he was nine.

But the narratives made the hours possible.

His back changed the quality of the hours. This was a fact he worked around the way you work around a bad knee — compensating, adjusting, planning your movements to minimise encounter. The lashes had been applied two days ago, which meant they had progressed from the first stage (a hot, wet fire that pulsed in time with his heartbeat) through the second (the tightening, as the welts rose and the surrounding skin contracted, every movement a small re-tearing) and into the third (the chronic ache, the dull presence that was almost background noise except when something touched them). His shirt was the enemy in this third stage. It had dried and adhered to the welts in several places, and every time it shifted — which was every time he breathed — a specific, targeted pain fired upward along his spine with the precision of a medical demonstration.

He had learned not to make a sound for this either.

He was not sure when, exactly, he had learned not to make sounds for anything. It had not been a decision. It had been an accumulation — each

silenced sound teaching his body that silence was the available response, until silence became the first response, the only response, the shape of him in relation to pain. He did not think this was unusual. He did not think about it at all. He simply sat with his knees to his chest and his hands locked around them, and felt his back announce itself on every inhale, and watched the light move.

When the amber reached the edges of the dresser and began pooling in the gap behind it, Adil allowed himself to change position. This was the calculation: enough time had passed that the slippers were unlikely to be making their directed journey. The house had settled into the particular quality of late-afternoon that meant whatever was going to happen had either already happened or would happen later, but not now. He extended his legs one at a time — the left first, always the left first, some habitual preference he had never examined — and felt the muscles protest, screaming the private language of cells too long held in one position. He bit the inside of his cheek. Not through the skin. Just enough pressure to give the pain somewhere specific.

In the gap between the rice sacks, the Observatory waited. He pressed his eye to the two-finger space and looked through to the column of light, where the dust moved and the afternoon was doing its quiet, reliable work of ending. In the narrow aperture of the Observatory, the world was only as large as what it showed him, and what it showed him was only light and particles, and this was the most uncomplicated version of the world Adil had ever found.

He stayed at the Observatory until the light was gone.

The call to prayer arrived at the perfect moment, as it always did — not because the timing was miraculous, but because Adil had calibrated his daily existence around it the way navigators once calibrated their crossings by the stars. The muezzin's voice came through the high window in fragments, carried on the humid evening air from the mosque two streets over, its loudspeakers crackling at the high notes in a way that should have been ugly and was instead, to Adil, the most reliable sound in the world.

Allahu Akbar.

God is great. He did not think about whether this was true. He thought about what came next: the shift from holding still to moving, the particular sequence of steps that constituted getting from the attic to the garage without making a sound, without creating the small doubt in the mind of whoever was below. He reached for his sneakers, which he had removed upon entering the attic and tucked them with their soles facing up against the dresser's left leg. Rubber on wood was too loud. Bare feet on wood could be managed.

He held the sneakers by their laces and stood. The standing was its own negotiation — the blood rushing back into his legs created a dizziness that he allowed to pass before he moved, because a dizzy boy navigating the attic in the dark was a boy who knocked things over. He stood until the world steadied. Then he began to move.

The attic stairs were nine steps. He descended them in contact with the wall rather than the centre, where the boards were older and more vocal. His hand trailed the plaster — cool, slightly damp from the day's heat and the house's particular breathlessness — and he used it as his reference point. At the base of the stairs, he turned left through the narrow door that led to the back corridor, then left again through the corridor that connected to the garage, and he did all of this without turning on any lights, because light announced presence the way sound did, and presence was the thing to be avoided.

The garage was a different kind of darkness. Deeper, more deliberate. It smelled of old oil and the particular dusty dryness of space that was covered but not quite sealed, where outside air came through in slow, patient infiltrations. There was no car. There had not been a car as long as Adil had been alive, though there were the artefacts of one: a cracked rubber mat on the oil-stained floor, a shelf of mechanical implements whose purposes he had never investigated. And there was the swing.

He was not sure who had put it up. The swing was a wooden plank on two lengths of rope, suspended from the exposed beam that ran across the centre of the garage ceiling. The ropes were old hemp, rough and slightly hairy against his palms when he gripped them — and the beam had a specific creak when weight was applied that he had also memorised, as he had memorised

everything about the spaces where he was allowed to be still. He sat on the plank and let his feet drag in the cool, compacted dirt of the garage floor, which was not concrete but something older — tamped earth that had hardened over decades into something approaching stone.

He began to swing.

Not large arcs. Small ones: three inches forward, three inches back, a barely perceptible rocking that the beam accommodated with its periodic low groan. The rhythm was the thing. The rhythm was the oldest technology for the management of an overloaded nervous system, and Adil had discovered it the same way he had discovered everything useful in his life — not through instruction but through the body's own emergency protocols, through trial and survival. Forward and back. The cool garage air against his face on the forward stroke, the stillness pressing back in on the back stroke.

In the rhythm, he processed the day.

This was not a deliberate process. He did not think: now I will process the day. He thought nothing at all, or nothing that had the consistency of thought. What happened was more like weather — the day's events rising and falling through him the way pressure systems move, arriving with their associated sensations, and then receding. The white-hot specific memory of pain. The specific quality of humiliation that came from being watched during pain, which was different from the pain itself. The weight of the morning assembly. The chalk in his hand during the mathematics problem. The way the room had gone hollow.

He swung in the dark until these things had moved through him sufficiently to allow sleep, and then he carried his sneakers back through the house, moving still in the language of whispers, and went to bed.

He did not sleep well. He never slept well. But he slept.

Chapter Two: Attendance

The alarm clock was a Soviet-era relic, a wind-up mechanism in a rounded chrome body that his mother had owned since before he was born. It sat on the nightstand at a distance calculated, it seemed to him, to be just beyond the reach of a sleeping hand — close enough to be heard, far enough to require standing to silence it. This was not an accident. His mother was not a person who did things by accident.

It screamed. That was the only word for the sound — a mechanical scream, a jagged edge of noise that tore through the particular quality of near-sleep with the precision of a blade. He had no preparation for it, ever. Every morning, it arrived as a surprise. Every morning, it tore the same wound.

He lay for a moment after silencing it with a slap, staring at the ceiling's water stain in the grey predawn light. The stain was shaped roughly like a hand — or had been, some years ago; it had evolved since, growing new fingers or losing them depending on how the season's damp was distributed. He had named it once, a private naming that he had never told anyone, a naming from before he understood that private things were not safe. He did not name things anymore.

The fatigue was particularly this morning. A full-body heaviness that was not just the muscles but something deeper — the kind of tired that a night's sleep addresses only tangentially, because it originates not in the body's need for rest but in the soul's ongoing work of being itself under conditions of sustained pressure. He was nine years old, and he was tired in a way that should belong to someone much older.

He dressed with mechanical precision. Shirt first, and this required

managing the back — the shirt had to be settled carefully against the welts, a process that involved a precise amount of forward lean and a precise angle of shoulder rotation, choreography he had worked out over many similar mornings. The trousers. The socks. The shoes, which he tied with the compulsive exactness of someone who has found that controlling small things is the available substitute for controlling large ones.

The bathroom. The face in the mirror: round, dark-eyed, carefully blank. He had been practising the blankness since the age of seven, when he had first understood that visible emotion — any visible emotion — was information that could be used against him. Fear made you a target. Sadness made you a burden. Anger made you a problem. The only safe expression was no expression, or the approximation of it: a face that reported nothing to the observer, that kept its accounts private.

He was getting better at it. The mirror showed him someone who looked, at a distance, like a normal child. He took this as progress.

His mother was not in the kitchen when he came down. This was statistically common — she worked until late, and on the mornings after the late nights, the kitchen was his alone for the twenty minutes before school. The bitter tea was already made; she had managed it before sleep, or someone had, some concession toward the structure of a morning. He drank it standing at the counter because sitting at the table required a chair, and the chair back met his spine at the specific altitude of the welts.

He ate nothing. His throat had the quality of a passage under construction — narrowed, difficult, as if the body was guarding against what went in and what came out. He had not been hungry for breakfast in so long that the concept of it had become theoretical.

He shouldered his school bag and left the house.

The street at this hour was its own world. The dusty particular light of early morning in Lahore in September — not yet hot, but carrying the specific promise of heat, the way a room smells of the dinner that will happen in it before any cooking has begun. The street trees, old eucalyptus and the occasional struggling neem, cast shadows that were still fresh. Other children were already in motion on the road, in the school uniforms that Adil also wore

but which felt, on him, different — as if the uniform designated membership in something he was not, in fact, a member of.

He watched them.

He was very good at watching. He had always been good at watching — it was the first skill he had developed, the foundational skill from which everything else followed. Watching was how you understood the temperature of a room before you entered it. Watching was how you mapped the likely trajectory of moods. Watching was the early warning system without which everything else was guesswork. He had developed it to a degree of precision that, in a different context, might have been called remarkable.

The other children moved through the morning in a way that Adil found genuinely difficult to comprehend. They shoved each other with affection. They shouted about cricket scores and television programs with an apparent certainty that these things mattered. They laughed at things that, as far as Adil could tell, were not objectively funny. They moved through the world as if it were a space that had been designed for their comfort, as if the architecture of the day was there to accommodate rather than to test.

He watched this as a student of an unfamiliar language watches native speakers — with intense attention, with the specific quality of comprehension that falls just short of complete understanding. He could identify the patterns. He could not feel the source.

They were a flock of sheep, he thought. Not with contempt — he had not yet arrived at the particular destination of contempt; that was years away. He thought it with something closer to bewilderment. They walked toward whatever was coming with their heads up and their eyes forward and their mouths full of noise, and they could not see that the world was closing in. He could not understand how they couldn't feel it.

He walked behind them, and inside him, nothing moved.

The school gate was presided over by the security guard, Rafiq, who had occupied this post for longer than Adil had been alive and who performed it with the weary authority of someone who has long since made peace with the limits of the job. He was a large man, going soft in the middle, with a grey moustache that he wore with the satisfaction of a man who considers it his

best feature. He liked children in the way of people who have no children of their own — at a pleasant distance, which could occasionally close without warning into something that was not distance at all.

Every morning, as Adil passed through the gate, Rafiq's hand would come out. Not to stop him — there was no stopping in the gesture, no interrogation of his right to enter. It was the specific movement of a hand toward a face, and then the fingers would find Adil's cheek, and they would pinch. Not hard. Hard would have been easier. It was a medium pressure, the pressure that is meant to say affection, that is calibrated to read as the warm gesture of an adult toward a child he likes. Rafiq smiled when he did it. His eyes creased at the corners. He said things like: "There he is," and "Getting chubby," and "What a face."

The first time it had happened, Adil had frozen. The second time, he had tried to angle his face away, and Rafiq's hand had followed, and the pinch had been harder that time, aimed at the avoidance itself. The third time, Adil had stood still.

He had stood still every time since.

He stood still now, feeling the fingers on his face, his skin crawling in a way that had nothing to do with temperature, his expression maintaining its careful blankness while his insides went through a process he had no words for. It was not pain, precisely. It was the specific sensation of having his body treated as a thing that was available — available to be touched, available to be assessed, available to be commented upon — without anyone asking whether he was available. It was the sensation of non-consultation. His own body is a surface that others could interact with without negotiating his presence in it.

"Getting chubby," Rafiq said again, releasing him.

Adil walked through the gate.

The schoolyard was a concrete square, bounded by the school's three main buildings in a U-shape that created a courtyard with an aspect in the mornings that was dusty and bright. The fig tree in the south corner was the oldest thing in the compound — older than the buildings, maybe. It was enormous in the way of old fig trees, the trunk thickened and wrinkled and silverish, the branches expanding in all directions in the pattern of something that grew

according to no plan except its own. Adil's route to his classroom took him past it, and every morning he put his hand on the bark for a moment. Not consciously. His hand just went there, drawn by some navigational imperative he had never examined.

The bark was his transition point. On one side of it: the gate, Rafiq, the street, the attic. On the other side: the classroom, the teacher, the long succession of hours.

He pressed his palm flat against the bark and stood for a moment. The fissures of the bark pressed back. He felt the depth and dimension of its texture — the grit of old growth, the places where moss had taken hold in the grooves and was soft in contrast to the hard ridges, the slight warmth where the sun had reached it. If he concentrated fully enough, the bark was the only thing. Just the texture. Just the sensation of material against skin, with no emotional weight attached, nothing it was telling him to do or be, nothing it expected.

He could stay at the bark for approximately forty-five seconds before the bell, which he calculated every morning by habit, and he used all forty-five of them.

Then he went to class.

Chapter Three: The Chalk

The mathematics classroom was the fourth door on the right of the upper corridor, which was where the smell of chalk met the smell of the building's particular damp, which was a different damp from the attic's damp — more institutional, more treated, but underneath the floor wax and the chalk and the accumulated exhalations of forty boys over many years, the same basic presence: moisture finding its way into stone, and staying.

Adil sat in the third row, second from the left. Not the front row — the front row attracted a specific kind of attention from teachers who interpreted proximity as eagerness, and Adil had no interest in being interpreted. Not the back row, where the boys who wanted to be elsewhere congregated and whose energy had a restless, disruptive quality that Adil found exhausting to be near. The third row was a calculation: visible enough to appear to be there, far enough back to avoid the front row's problems, close enough to the window that, when necessary, there was something to look at that was not the classroom.

Mr Hussain arrived at 8:15, which was four minutes after the bell, which was consistent with his usual timing. He was a man of sharp angles — the word that came to Adil when he thought about him was angular, because everything about him was composed of edges: the pronounced bones of his face, the precise crease of his trousers, the acute triangles of his elbows when he folded his arms, which he did often. He moved through the classroom with a quality that Adil had identified and filed without quite having a name for — a softness of foot, a quality of approach that was not heavy, that announced itself later than it should. He had the gait of someone who has spent time

considering how they are heard.

“Adil.” He said it on the third scan of the room, his eyes moving across the rows before landing and fixing. “Come to the board.”

The board was at the front of the class. Walking to it required passing between the desks and the blackboard, crossing the space where everyone could see you from behind, where your back faced the room. Adil rose, moved through the rows, and picked up the chalk from the tray at the bottom of the blackboard. The chalk was dry and brittle, the kind that had been in the tray too long and had developed a slight crumble at the ends. It felt unreliable in his fingers.

On the blackboard, in Mr Hussain’s angular script, was a long-division problem. Three digits divided by two digits, remainder expected. Adil looked at it. The numbers were clear. He understood the process. He had always been better at mathematics than at the things that required holding words in his head — mathematics had a quality of fixity, of rules that applied consistently, that made it navigable in a way that language, with its exceptions and reversals, often wasn’t.

He began to write. His numbers were neat, taking up less space on the board than they needed to. He worked through the problem step by step, the chalk scraping against the blackboard in the specific register of chalk on slate, a sound that was everywhere in the room. Behind him, the class was thirty-nine other boys in their seats, a collective presence he was aware of without turning to see. He focused on the numbers.

He felt Mr Hussain move before he heard him.

It was not a sound. It was a displacement. A change in the quality of the air behind him, the specific sensation of a body moving through space toward you, the near-imperceptible warmth differential of a person getting closer. Adil continued writing. He kept his chalk on the board. He kept his numbers in their column.

Mr Hussain arrived at his shoulder. This itself was not unusual — teachers came to observe, to correct, to demonstrate. What happened next was unusual, or should have been: Mr Hussain’s hand arrived at the side of Adil’s waist. Not his shoulder, not his arm. His waist. With the pretence of adjusting

his positioning, of guiding his arm in the demonstration of the correct angle for the chalk stroke, the hand settled. It stayed. The pressure was deliberate and slow in a way that a corrective hand is not slow, that a guiding hand is not slow. A guiding hand moves; this one rested.

The room did not go cold.

The room went hollow.

This was the sensation: as if the acoustic properties of the space had changed, as if the thirty-nine boys in their chairs and the chalk and the blackboard and the smell of floor wax had all receded simultaneously to a great distance, and what remained was the two-square-inch area of contact and the deliberate, specific quality of what it was. The sensation was not pain. Pain, Adil knew well; pain had clear physics, clear causes, clear durations. This had none of that clarity. This was a different kind of knowing, the kind that arrived fully formed without having been assembled, the kind the body carries out before the mind has been consulted.

He finished the problem.

His handwriting was not good. He could see this without anyone telling him — the numbers that had started neatly were shaking by the last line, barely legible, as if the chalk had been operated by hands with different instructions than his mind was giving. He set the chalk down. He turned. Mr. Hussain was already back at the front of the room, gesturing toward the board with his angular hands, saying something about the method.

Adil returned to his seat.

He sat down very carefully, because sitting required him to be deliberate about his spine, and also because he was uncertain about his legs. There was a quality to them that he associated with the aftermath of certain things — a hollow feeling, an unreliability. He placed his hands flat on the desk. He looked at the textbook. The numbers in the textbook were very clear. He focused on the numbers.

Lunch, he went to the corridor. Not the one nearest the courtyard, where the other boys ate and made their noise, but the side corridor adjacent to the old storage rooms, where the light was different — cooler, more diffuse, with none of the direct sun that arrived in the courtyard and announced itself. He

sat with his back against the wall. He did not eat. He opened his sketchbook.

The sketchbook was a standard exercise book that he had emptied of its pages and covered with brown paper. He had been carrying it for eight months. He drew in it in pencil, sometimes in the blue ballpoint he used for schoolwork. He drew what he could see from where he sat — the end of the corridor, the junction where it met the main building, the way the light changed as it came around the corner. He drew the wall's texture, the specific arrangement of bricks in the lower section where the pointing had begun to fail, and the mortar was receding. He drew the shadows that the afternoon sun cast through the corridor's single high window, the way they fell across the floor in parallelograms that shifted as he watched.

He was not skilled in a technical sense. His perspective was instinctive rather than learned. His proportions followed their own logic rather than an objective one. But within the limits of what he was drawing, there was a precision — an attention to the specific, to the actual surface of things rather than the conventional representation of them, that made the drawings look more like observation records than art.

On the paper, he was the master.

On the paper, nothing arrived at his shoulder without announcement. Nothing touched without his chalk moving first, nothing settled without his hand setting it in place. The line went where he put it. The shadow was where he drew the shadow. In the forty minutes of the lunch break, he filled four pages with the corridor, its light, its textures, its shadows, and by the time the bell went, he had managed to return to something approaching his own temperature.

He closed the sketchbook and went back to class.

He did not tell anyone. This was not a decision. There was no one to tell, in the sense that there was no one whose response to being told would be to fix the thing that was wrong. He understood this with the same unsentimental precision with which he understood the physics of the attic. The available options were: tell someone and have it made worse, or don't tell someone and have it be only what it was. He chose the second option, not because he was brave, but because he was experienced.

Chapter Four: The Tuition

The tuition centre was on Fareed Road, fifteen minutes by auto-rickshaw from the school, and it operated from 3:30 pm to 9:30 pm on weekdays and from 9:00 am to 6:00 pm on Saturdays. It was housed in a two-storey building that had been a residence before being converted, and the conversion had been managed with the primary goal of fitting as many students as possible into as many rooms as possible, which meant that the rooms were too small for their purpose and the furniture was arranged with a density that created the sensation of being in a room that was continuing to shrink. Adil had been attending since the beginning of the school year, which meant three months, which meant something in the neighbourhood of two hundred and forty hours.

Fauzia was the English teacher. She was not a teacher by training. She was a woman of forty-two with a degree in Urdu literature and a method that had been taught to her in turn by teachers who had been taught it in turn, passed down intact through generations of instruction: you hold the pipe until the student can repeat the passage. The question of comprehension is secondary to the question of storage. Storage is achieved through repetition. Repetition is ensured through the pipe.

The pipe was plastic, approximately sixty centimetres long, flexible enough to sting without leaving the kind of mark that needed immediate explaining. Fauzia kept it under the desk, which everyone in the room knew, which was the point of it being kept there.

The English passage today was three pages. It was about different types of animals and their habitats, written in a style designed for nine-year-olds in a

country where English was a second language, which meant it was simple in construction but demanded of a child whose brain was already at capacity an act of pure mechanical storage that had nothing to do with understanding. The passage had to be recited from memory by the end of the session.

Adil had been trying to read the passage for forty minutes.

The problem was not the English, though the English was difficult. The problem was that his brain, today, was operating at a remove from the page. Reading required a certain quality of contact between the eyes and the words — a quality that he could usually, with effort, achieve. Today, the words were doing something else. They were moving. Not literally, not in the way of a visual disturbance, but they were refusing to hold still in the sense that his mind required them to hold still, refusing to cohere into the kind of memory that could be retrieved on demand. He read a sentence. He went to the next. He lost the first. He went back. He lost the second. He was a person trying to fill a container that had a hole in it.

His back was not helping. His back was having its own conversation with his nervous system, a conversation that was getting louder as the afternoon wore on, as the position required for sitting at the small desk pushed fabric against skin in the manner of slow, insistent pressure. The pain was not dramatic. It was persistent. A persistent pain is more corrosive than a dramatic one, because a dramatic pain demands all of your attention and, in doing so, becomes the only thing, whereas a persistent pain inserts itself between you and everything else you are trying to do.

He was aware of the pipe. The awareness of the pipe was its own separate processing load: a background process running continuously, consuming resources, tracking the position of Fauzia's hands, her expressions, the quality of the silence when a student stumbled.

"Adil." Her voice was not raised. This was sometimes worse. "Read."

He looked at the page. He found the place. He began: "A cow. A cow is an animal that is." He reached for the next word. The next word was not where he had left it. His brain had closed that file without notification. He stood at the place where the word should have been and found the void.

He tried a different route: he had read the sentence before; somewhere in

the machinery of his memory, it should be stored, if not as a recallable fact then as a pattern. He tried to find the pattern. There was no pattern. There was only the white, specific silence of a brain that had run out of processing space and was returning a null result.

“A cow is a type of.” He stopped. The room was entirely quiet in the way of rooms that are waiting. “A cow is a type of animal.”

He had already said that. He could hear that he had already said it. He repeated himself in the specific manner of someone trying to hold a position that is already lost, returning to the known terrain because the unknown is impossible.

The silence after was not long. The whistle came — the specific sibilant sound of the pipe passing through air, a sound that could only mean one thing, that had never meant anything else — and then the first blow arrived across his shoulders with the precision of something that had practice. He had not moved. He had not tried to protect himself. He had learned from earlier experiences that protective motion was noted and resulted in the blow being redirected to wherever the protection was not.

He stood still.

She struck him six times. The first three were along the back, which was its own specific category of agony, given the existing welts — the impacts landing on raised, angry tissue, reopening or intensifying what was already there, the pain no longer being a fire but something beyond fire, something with a physical quality like being taken apart. The last three were across his arms and hands, which he had raised not to protect himself but in the automatic, uncontrolled response of a body to repeated impact.

When it was over, she put the pipe back under the desk. She said: “Again. From the beginning.”

He picked up the page. His hands were shaking. He could see them shaking with the detachment of an observer watching someone else’s hands. He began to read.

He did not recite the passage from memory by the end of the session. He got halfway through, stumbled, was struck again, got three-quarters through, stumbled, was struck again, and by 9:30 pm, when the session ended, what

he had managed was a broken, approximate version of the passage that bore enough resemblance to the original to constitute, in Fauzia's calculus, a partial success.

He sat in the corner of the room after the other students had filed out, in the particular posture of a body that has decided to take up as little space as possible. His knees were at his chest. His chin was on his knees. He was not crying. Crying required a kind of presence that he had, for the moment, vacated. He was simply waiting — waiting in the way that things wait when there is nothing else to be done: a stone waits, a building waits, something with no agency over what happens next waits.

His mother arrived at 2:00 am. He heard the auto-rickshaw before he saw the headlights through the window. He heard her voice at the door, the brief exchange with the building's night watchman, her footsteps on the stairs. When she entered the room and found him in the corner, she did not say anything. She crossed to him, and he reached for the edge of her grey scarf — he did not think about this; his hand just went there — and pressed the fabric against his face. It was the only soft thing.

"Come," she said. Her voice had the quality of something wrung out. Not cold, not warm. A voice that was handling as much as it could handle.

In the auto-rickshaw home, with his head against her arm and her arm around his shoulders (carefully, avoiding the back, she knew by now where to avoid), Adil looked out the window at the city moving past. The night streets of Lahore were a different city from the day streets — quieter but not quiet, still in motion but a different motion, the traffic down to a comparative trickle and the people on the pavements moving with the particular purposefulness of people who are somewhere late and know it. The street lamps threw orange circles across the road and into them. Adil watched the circles approach and recede and approach and recede and felt his mother's arm, and that was enough to constitute a kind of safety. Not actual safety. The approximate version. The available version.

At home, she sat him on the bathroom stool and lifted his shirt. She did not say anything when she saw the back. She had said things before, in earlier weeks, and the things had not helped, and she was pragmatic in the way of

people whose lives have required them to be pragmatic above all else. She opened the medicine cabinet and took out the brown bottle of antiseptic, the gauze and the petroleum jelly, and she applied them in the order that had by now become procedural. The antiseptic stung; this he allowed himself to make a small sound for, a sharp intake through his teeth, which she acknowledged by slowing her hand.

She put him to bed. She sat on the edge of the mattress until his breathing evened. He did not sleep for a long time after she left — he lay listening to the house settle, listening to the distant city, feeling the careful equilibrium of a body that has been through too much and is now deciding whether it wants to be vertical again tomorrow.

He decided, eventually, that it did.

The alarm would scream in four hours.

He was still there to hear it.

II

Act Two: False Freedom

Chapter Five: Sarfraz

He met Sarfraz in October, which was when Lahore's heat finally acknowledged the calendar and began to soften at the edges — not cool, not yet, but the particular quality of heat that had decided to negotiate rather than simply insist. The mornings became possible. The evenings became almost pleasant. And in this slight relaxation of the city's grip, a boy could stand in the schoolyard near the fig tree and breathe without it being an act of physical will.

Sarfraz was new. He arrived in the middle of the first week of the month, which was an unusual time to arrive — mid-term arrivals were generally the result of transfers or disruptions, families that had moved or situations that had changed, and they carried with them the specific quality of people who are navigating a new social geography without a map. Most new arrivals handled this by attaching quickly to whatever group seemed most hospitable, which was usually the noisiest and most assured group, because assurance in a schoolyard is indistinguishable from authority. Sarfraz did not do this. He stood near the fig tree on his first morning with the quiet attention of someone who was watching before deciding, and this was the thing that made Adil look at him twice.

He knew the quality of watching. He had practised it himself.

He did not approach. Adil did not approach people; this would have required a recalibration of his entire operational posture, and his operational posture had been calibrated for a long time around not being noticed. But the next morning Sarfraz was at the fig tree again, and the morning after that, and on the fourth morning he was sitting on the exposed root — the

large, arching root on the south side that surfaced before diving back into the ground, creating a natural seat — and drawing in a notebook, and Adil stopped walking when he saw this because it was the most unexpected thing he had seen in some time.

“What are you drawing?” he said. He had not planned to say anything. The question arrived before his editorial function could prevent it.

Sarfraz looked up. He had a broad, open face — the kind of face that does not arrange itself into the guarded configuration that Adil’s had learned to maintain. He looked at Adil without the usual social assessment, without the rapid calculation of threat and opportunity that Adil associated with being looked at. He just looked.

“The tree,” he said. He turned the notebook around. The drawing was not very good in the technical sense — he had not found the perspective, and the trunk was too narrow for the mass of the branches — but the attention was there. He had spent time looking at the fig tree and had drawn what he saw, and what he had seen was more than most people saw.

“You got the bark right,” Adil said.

Sarfraz looked at the drawing, then back at Adil, then at the tree. “The wrinkles,” he said.

“The wrinkles,” Adil confirmed.

They looked at the tree together for a moment. The fig tree in the morning was lit from the east, which meant the wrinkles of the bark were in relief — each ridge and groove catching light on one face and shadow on the other, the surface becoming three-dimensional in a way that it wasn’t in flat afternoon light. Adil had never discussed this with anyone because there had never been anyone to discuss it with.

“I have a sketchbook,” he said.

“Can I see?”

He considered this. The sketchbook was not exactly private in the sense of containing anything that would harm him if seen — it had no words, no confessions, nothing that reported on the interior. It was just drawings. But it was also the only space in his life that was entirely his own, that had not been invaded or commented upon, and there was a risk in showing it — the

risk that whoever saw it would say something that would change the way he thought about it, that would coat it with someone else's interpretation and make it harder to use.

He took it out of his bag. He handed it to Sarfraz.

Sarfraz looked through it slowly. He did not say it was good. He did not say it was bad. He paused at the four pages of the corridor — the light, the textures, the shadows — and held them up to the morning light, and then he set the book on his knee and looked at the school building in front of him, locating, apparently, the corridor that Adil had drawn.

"You drew the same shadow three times," he said. "But each one is different."

"The light was moving," Adil said.

"Yeah." Sarfraz handed the book back with the care of someone returning something that matters. "Yeah."

That was the beginning. It was not a dramatic beginning. It was the kind of beginning that only becomes visible in retrospect, when you can look back and identify the day that the geography changed, the day the map acquired a new landmark. At the time, it felt like nothing more than standing at the fig tree with another person, which was something Adil had never done, and discovering that the tree was the same whether you were alone or not, which should have been obvious but wasn't.

Sarfraz was from Multan, which he pronounced with the particular weight of a person who misses somewhere without entirely admitting it. His father had been transferred to Lahore for work — something in textiles, something that moved the family from a large house in a quieter city to an apartment in Gulberg in a neighbourhood that Sarfraz described as "very noisy and very sure of itself." He had a younger sister whom he appeared to regard with uncomplicated affection. He liked mangoes more than any other food, which he mentioned unprompted on their second conversation as if it were a relevant biographical detail. He found mathematics easier than languages but less interesting. He drew in his spare time and had decided, without much drama about it, that this was something he would keep doing.

He asked Adil questions that were direct without being interrogative — questions that felt like genuine curiosity rather than the social navigation that

disguises itself as curiosity. What did Adil draw when he wasn't at school? What did he do in the afternoons? (Adil said he went to tuition. He did not say anything else.) What was his neighbourhood like? Did he have brothers or sisters? The questions created, over weeks, something like a portrait — or the beginning of one, the rough outline that precedes detail.

In return, Adil found himself answering more than he had answered anyone in memory. Not fully — he maintained his editorial function on anything that related to the interior geography of home, to the attic, to the back, to the tuition sessions. But around the edges of these things, in the space of art and observation and the specific attention they both gave to surfaces, there was a conversation that felt, with a novelty Adil could not quite name, like contact.

One afternoon in late October, Sarfraz produced a set of charcoals. "My uncle sent them," he said. "From Karachi. He's an artist."

Adil held one, feeling the weight of it, the specific crumble of charcoal between his fingers — denser than a pencil, less precise but with a quality of mark that was different, that could be smudged into gradients or pressed hard for black. He made a mark on the back of his hand. It was immediate in a way pencil wasn't — the mark was there before he had quite decided to make it.

"Have you used them before?" Sarfraz asked.

"No."

"They're harder than a pencil. You have to accept that you can't control everything."

Adil looked at the mark on the back of his hand. A smudge. Uncontrolled edges. He thought about this.

"Okay," he said, and he drew something, and it was the fig tree's bark, and it was better than anything he had drawn with a pencil, because the uncontrolled edges were where the bark lived.

On the days he spent part of a morning or lunch break with Sarfraz, the arithmetic of his nervous system came out differently. Not resolved. Not fixed. But different — as if the presence of someone who did not require performance, who did not have an agenda related to Adil's body or his compliance or his memory for English passages, had some quality of

recalibration. He did not think this through. He simply noticed, with the observational precision he applied to everything, that the afternoons were more manageable on those days. That the attic, when he reached it, was less necessary.

He did not tell Sarfraz any of this. He did not have the language for it, and even if he had had the language, the habit of non-disclosure was too old and too structural to simply step around. But something was being quietly, permanently altered. The map was getting a second landmark.

Chapter Six: The Shopkeeper's Window

Fareed Road was the kind of street that served its immediate neighbourhood without aspiring to serve anyone else. Not the wide, commercial density of the main bazaar roads but something narrower and more habitual — the kind of street where the same people arrived at the same times for the same purchases with the specific ease of long custom, where shopkeepers knew their customers' orders before they were given, and where the street itself had the quality of a room that is used every day.

There was a general goods shop three buildings down from the tuition centre. It had been there, Adil estimated, for decades — the kind of shop that had accumulated its inventory over generations, adding new things without removing old ones until the interior was a compressed archaeology of consumer goods: cooking oil next to school supplies next to stationery next to mobile phone accessories next to the particular class of miscellaneous items for which there is no category name. The window display was changed occasionally, with no apparent logic, so that some days it showed packaged biscuits, some days stationery and some days nothing at all except the dusty space of a display case that had been emptied and not yet refilled.

On the days with stationery, Adil stopped.

It had started as practical — he had run out of pencils in the third week of October and needed to replace them, and the general goods shop was closer than anywhere else. He had gone in, made the purchase with the money his mother left on the kitchen counter in a small pile on Tuesday and Friday mornings, and on his way out had stopped at the display of sketchbooks. Not the exercise-book variety that he was currently using, but actual sketchbooks

— wire-bound, with heavy cream paper, the kind designed for the specific purpose. He had picked one up. He had looked at the price. He had put it back.

But the location was now on his map.

After tuition, on the days when there was a gap between the session ending and his mother arriving, he came to the window. The shopkeeper's name was Jaleel. He was not behind the counter on the first occasion that Adil stopped at the window; he was in the back, dealing with a supplier, and Adil stood at the window alone, looking in at the display, which that day was three kinds of rulers and a set of geometry instruments in a blue plastic case.

Jaleel came to the window on the second occasion. He had been behind the counter this time, and he had looked up when he saw Adil stop, and he had come to the front to see what the boy was looking at. He was forty-three years old, of medium height, with the slight forward lean of a person who spent most of their day behind counters. He had a full face with soft features — an incongruously gentle face for a man of his size, the kind of face that reads as safe in the way of certain faces that have cultivated this quality through practice. He had kind eyes. Adil noted the eyes, because he noted everything, and filed them under the category of people whose eyes said one thing — although he had not yet learned to fully read what that thing was or why it made him uneasy in a way he couldn't immediately place.

"You're looking at the sketchbooks," Jaleel said. He had come to stand in the doorway of the shop. Not blocking it. Just in it.

"Yes," Adil said.

"Are you an artist?"

The question was unusual. Adults generally did not ask children what they were with the direct quality of a genuine enquiry. They asked what they wanted to be, which was a different question and anticipated a different category of answer: doctor, engineer, cricketer. Adil stood for a moment with the question, turning it over.

"I draw," he said.

"That's the same thing." Jaleel smiled. He had a good smile — the kind that involved the whole face. "Come inside. I'll show you something."

This was the first occasion. In retrospect — in the retrospect that came much later, that came after the price had been paid and the damage had been assessed and the thing had been understood for what it was — Adil would return to this moment and try to identify what he should have seen. The answer was that there was nothing obviously wrong with it. A shopkeeper, seeing a child interested in art supplies, invites the child inside to look at the merchandise. This is a transaction. It happens every day in every shop in every city.

He went inside.

What Jaleel showed him was the back wall, above the shelves of exercise books and ruler sets — a collection of drawings, framed in thin aluminium frames, six of them in a rough grid. They were pencil drawings, precise and dense, of the Lahore cityscape: the interior of the Badshahi Mosque, the back streets of the old city, the food market near the Data Darbar shrine at night. They were skilled in a way that Adil immediately recognised — not as someone who understood technique in a theoretical sense, but as someone who understood looking, who recognised in the drawings the quality of sustained, specific attention.

“You drew these,” Adil said.

“I did. A long time ago.” Jaleel stood beside him, looking at the drawings. “I used to think I would do this — make things. Draw. Eventually paint. Life went another direction.”

“Why?”

A pause. Adil was not usually comfortable with pauses; they contained the possibility of turns he wasn’t ready for. But this pause felt different. It felt like genuine consideration.

“It’s a story,” Jaleel said. “Not a short one. Would you like some tea?”

Tea was offered in shops — this was normal. The offering of tea was the commercial language of hospitality, the establishment of context that preceded negotiation or exchange. Adil was aware of this. He also calculated: his mother would arrive in forty minutes. Forty minutes was enough.

“Yes,” he said.

He stayed for thirty-five minutes. He drank the tea, which was sweet and

strong in the Lahori style, and he looked at the drawings on the wall, and Jaleel told him about the drawings — not about technique, but about the places, about the specific days he had gone to draw in the Badshahi Mosque, about what it was like to sit in the enormous courtyard in the early morning with a sketchbook, about the light at that hour. He talked about light the way Adil thought about light, which was as a quality rather than a condition, as something with character and agency that changed the nature of what it landed on.

He was interesting to listen to. He was knowledgeable without being instructional. He directed questions at Adil that had the quality of genuine enquiry — what did Adil draw? Where did he find places to draw? Had he ever tried ink?

Adil answered. He described the corridor at school. He described the attic window. (Not the attic — just the window, the specific quality of the light through the grime-filmed glass.) He described the fig tree at dawn.

“You pay attention,” Jaleel said.

“I always have,” Adil said.

“That’s the only real skill. Everything else can be taught.”

When his mother’s auto-rickshaw appeared at the end of the street, Adil set down his cup and thanked Jaleel and left. He carried the conversation with him the way you carry a found object that you’re not sure what to do with — held carefully, at a slight distance from the other things you’re carrying, pending classification.

He came back the next week.

And the week after that.

And then it was simply part of the map: Fareed Road, the tuition centre, and the shop, in the gap between the session ending and his mother arriving, where he drank sweet tea and talked about light and looked at the drawings on the wall, and where Jaleel listened to him with the specific quality of attention that he had, in his entire life, been given by almost no one.

This was the mechanism. Not sudden. Not dramatic. The mechanism was a slow, consistent accumulation of a thing Adil was desperately low on, offered in the specific deficit-addressing form that made it feel essential before he

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had understood what it was. You give a starving person food, and they do not analyse the gift; they simply eat. Adil was given attention, and he took it, and it felt like survival, and this was the mechanism.

Chapter Seven: What Attention Costs

December arrived with the cold that Lahore practised in its particular way — not the cold of elevation, nothing dramatic, but a chill that came in during the nights and did not entirely leave during the days, so that the mornings were grey and the streets were quiet until mid-morning and the tea in Jaleel's shop was something you held with both hands.

The shop had become familiar. Adil knew its specific geography the way he knew the attic's: the shelf heights, the smell (cardamom from the tea box, old paper from the receipt books, the synthetic sweetness of packaged biscuits, and under it all the warm, oily smell of the counter's wood). He knew where Jaleel kept the charcoals — a drawer below the sketchbooks, a brand he had never seen elsewhere, in a long black box. He had begun to suspect that Jaleel stocked these specifically. The shop otherwise carried only the basic art supplies appropriate to its neighbourhood — pencils, compass sets, standard exercise books — but the charcoals were unusual, specialist, the kind you ordered.

He did not ask. The not-asking was its own form of knowledge: he was aware that some questions, once answered, could not be unanswered, and he was not ready to possess the answers.

The pattern of the visits had evolved. In the first months, they had been in conversation: tea, the drawings on the wall, Jaleel talking about light and place, Adil talking about what he drew. Then Jaleel had shown him things. He had a collection of art books — actual publications, not textbooks — and he brought these out one at a time with the specific pleasure of someone sharing something they value. Adil saw, for the first time, reproductions

of Van Gogh's interiors (the rooms, not the famous flowers — the rooms at Arles, the small beds and chairs rendered in thick strokes as if the paint was a physical force), of Rembrandt's etchings, of Zainul Abedin's sketches of the Bengali famine of 1943, which were the most powerful things he had ever seen.

"He drew these when people were dying around him," Jaleel said. "With a reed pen. On whatever paper he could find."

Adil looked at the bent figures, the angular hunger in the lines, the bodies that were shapes of suffering before they were shapes of people. He felt something move in him that he didn't have a name for — a recognition that art could hold things that were real and terrible and still be art, that the translation from experience to drawing was not a sanitisation but an intensification.

"Why?" he said.

"Why did he draw them?"

"Yes."

"Because witnessing matters. Because if you look at something and then record that you looked, you've done something to it — something that changes what it is. You've refused to let it be only what it was."

Adil held this. He turned it over the way he turned all things over, examining it from different angles, testing its weight.

"Is that why you drew the mosque?" he said.

"Yes." A pause that was different from other pauses. "And other things."

The change in the visits was gradual. It was not that Jaleel became different; it was that the closeness became different. He had always been close in the sense of the small shop, which required proximity, which required leaning over the counter to show the art books and sitting on adjacent stools to look at the drawings together. But there was a way in which proximity can modulate — a way in which it can go from being the physical requirement of a shared activity to being the activity itself, without anything specific marking the transition.

One afternoon in mid-December, looking at the Abedin reproductions, Jaleel's hand rested on Adil's shoulder. It rested with the naturalness of a

habit. Adil looked at the hand and then at the page and then at the hand again. He did not move. He did not say anything. He had spent his life in the careful management of what he communicated through movement, and the most thorough training of that management had been: do not make it worse by indicating awareness. So he indicated nothing.

The hand stayed for a moment and then was withdrawn. The conversation continued.

The next time it was longer.

He noticed, during the third time, that the quality of the touch had changed in the way he knew how to identify changes. Not the quality of a hand resting, but of a hand that was resting with intent — a hand that was being placed rather than merely present. He was aware of this. His awareness of it was the kind that filled the body before the mind had assembled the language, a physical knowledge that ran ahead of cognition and landed first in the stomach as a specific weight, and in the throat as a narrowing.

He finished his tea. He said he had to go.

He walked to the end of Fareed Road and sat on the edge of the kerb and stayed there for ten minutes, not thinking. Not thinking was not the same as not feeling; it was the specific suspension of cognition that his nervous system deployed in the aftermath of things that were too complex to process in real time. He sat on the kerb and let his eyes follow the traffic without interpreting what they saw, until the ten minutes were done and his mother's auto-rickshaw appeared and he got in.

He went back to the shop.

He went back because the drawings on the wall were still there, and the art books were still there, and Jaleel's knowledge of light and observation was still there, and because the thing that felt like being seen — the specific quality of attention that he had built up into something structural, something load-bearing in his daily architecture — was still there. He went back because not going back was not an option he had yet built. He had not yet understood that the absence of an alternative is not the same as consent, that need and acceptance are not the same emotion wearing the same face, that a starving person eating from a hand they distrust is still starving.

He went back because he was ten years old and he had no map of this country.

The visits continued through December and into January. Adil compartmentalised with the efficiency he had developed over years of managing disparate, incompatible experiences — the attic and the school and the tuition all occupied the same life without becoming each other, and so he added the shop to the compartments and kept its contents separate from the other compartments, touching none of them. He drew in his sketchbook. He talked about light with Jaleel. He drank the sweet tea. He did not think about the hand.

Meanwhile, Sarfraz had begun to notice things.

Not the specific things — Sarfraz did not know about the shop, Jaleel or Fareed Road after tuition. But he noticed the quality of Adil's absence in the periods when Adil was managing the shop's compartment — a distracted quality, a quality of Adil being slightly elsewhere even when he was physically present. They were drawing together most mornings now, Sarfraz with his charcoals and Adil with his pencils, and Sarfraz had the specific sensitivity of a person who pays attention to paying attention, which meant he was aware when Adil's attention was reduced.

"Are you okay?" he asked one morning. Direct. No preamble.

Adil looked at him. "Yes," he said.

Sarfraz held the look for a moment. He did not press. He went back to his drawing.

But the next morning, he was at the fig tree early, earlier than usual, and he had brought two cups of tea in the small clay cups from the dhaba near the school gate. He handed one to Adil without explanation, and they drank tea in the winter morning and drew the fig tree, and Adil felt the quality of the question still in the air — not pressing, just there, like a held door.

He did not walk through it. But he noticed it was held.

Chapter Eight: The Texture of Deception

January hardened. The cold became more definite, the mornings sharp with the particular dry cold of the Punjab plain in winter, the grass along the school wall frost-pale at dawn and thawed by ten. Adil had begun to wear a second shirt under his uniform, which gave the welts a layer of cushioning but also made the shirt's material more constant against the back, which was a trade-off he worked through every morning with the pragmatism of chronic pain management.

In January, Jaleel gave him a sketchbook.

It was the wire-bound cream-paper kind, the one that Adil had looked at in the window display months ago and priced and put back. He arrived at the shop one Tuesday evening, and it was on the counter, and Jaleel said, "For you. I ordered it specifically." And when Adil said he couldn't take it, Jaleel said: "You can. Consider it a birthday gift in advance, or a New Year's gift. Consider it what it is: a thing for a person who needs it."

Adil held the sketchbook. He ran his thumb along the edge of the cream pages, feeling the slight texture of the paper's surface, which was different from exercise book paper — more resistant, with a tooth that would hold charcoal rather than smear it.

"Thank you," he said.

"Show me what you do with it."

He took it home. He did not draw in it that night; he set it on the small table beside his bed and looked at it for a while before sleeping. It was the most direct, unconditional gift he had received in a period of time he couldn't precisely identify. Things in his life were given with conditions

attached — with the expectation of performance, of return, of demonstration of gratitude at a level proportional to the gift. This had been given without visible conditions, and the absence of visible conditions was both the thing that made it feel like a genuine gift and the thing that made a part of him — the part that had been observing for years — quietly take note.

He began to draw in it the following morning.

He drew the sketchbook's own cover first, which was a beige cardstock with a faint grid embossed into it. He drew the quality of the paper's surface under oblique morning light. He drew the table it sat on, the ring of moisture left by his teacup, and the corner of the window above it. He drew these things with the specific attention that the quality of the paper invited, which was an attention that could take its time, that could revisit and build and smudge and correct.

Over the following weeks, the sketchbook became the primary record of his attention. He filled it with the fig tree at different hours, with the school corridor, with the back streets near the tuition centre, with the faces of people on buses seen through windows (not their features — he did not draw faces, had not drawn a face since very early, as if the face was too direct a thing, too exposed). He filled it with textures: the brick wall outside the tuition centre, the bark of the neem trees on the street, the specific surface of the garage floor with its tamped-earth compression, each detail rendered with a focus that became, during the drawing, the only thing in the world.

Jaleel asked to see it. He asked with the specific quality of someone who had the right to ask, which meant he asked simply, as if the question were ordinary, without the tentative quality of a request.

Adil showed him.

Jaleel looked through it slowly. He did not say it was good; he had never said anything was good or bad. He asked questions — not “why did you draw this” but “how long were you sitting here,” “what time of day,” “what was the light doing.” He asked questions about the experience of drawing, not the outcome of it, which was the question Adil had never been asked and which turned out to produce a different conversation than the usual one. He found himself describing the process — the way his hand sometimes went ahead of

his eye, the way certain textures required multiple passes to find, the way he had drawn the garage floor six times before finding the right weight of line.

"The floor," Jaleel said. He was looking at the garage floor pages. "This is a specific floor. I can tell from the way you've drawn it that you've spent a lot of time there."

"Yes," Adil said.

"Where is it?"

A pause. The pause was Adil's editorial function running its check.

"Home," he said. "The garage."

Jaleel looked up from the sketchbook. He held the look for a moment — the specific quality of a look that was assembling something, making connections between pieces of information that had been offered over months. Adil was aware of being read. He was aware of Jaleel reading him, and he was aware that Jaleel was good at reading him, and this awareness occupied the same location in his body as the awareness of the hand, the same location in his stomach.

"You spend a lot of time in your garage," Jaleel said.

"Sometimes," Adil said. The editorial function had decided this.

Jaleel handed the sketchbook back. His face returned to its natural configuration. The moment passed.

But something had shifted. Adil walked home that evening with the awareness of the shift — not able to name it, not able to locate it exactly, but aware that something had been redistributed. The shop felt differently weighted now, like a room that has been subtly rearranged: everything in approximately the same place, but the space feels altered.

He drew that night in the sketchbook. He drew the shop from memory — the shelves, the art books, the drawings on the back wall. He drew Jaleel's face with more attention than he had given to any face in the sketchbook before, the round features, the lines at the eyes, the specific quality of the expression when he looked at drawings.

He looked at the drawing for a long time before he closed the sketchbook.

He was aware of something he was not ready to think. He held the awareness at the edge of cognition, where things exist without requiring

examination, and left it there. He would think about it later. Or he wouldn't. Either way, he had drawn the face, and the face was in the sketchbook, and the sketchbook was his, and this constituted some form of record, even if he was not sure yet of what it was a record.

He closed the sketchbook. He turned off the light. He lay in the dark with the awareness at the edge and waited for sleep.

Sleep came eventually, as it always did eventually.

In the morning, the shop was still on his map.

Chapter Nine: What The Body Knows

February.

The thing about the body is that it knows things before the mind decides to know them. It has its own epistemology, its own way of processing evidence and arriving at conclusions, and these conclusions arrive as physical facts — as nausea, or cold, or the specific constriction of a throat that has received information it does not want, or the absence of hunger in a body that should be hungry, or the quality of a night's sleep that is architecturally wrong even when the day that preceded it was, by surface measures, ordinary.

Adil's body had been knowing things about the shop for some time before his mind agreed to look at what it knew.

The visit in the second week of February was the one that could not be re-filed.

He arrived at the usual time — 9:45 pm, the gap between the tuition session ending and his mother's arrival. The shop was quiet; it was a weeknight, and the street had the specific stillness of late-week evenings when people were inside with their families and the commercial activity of the road had wound down to the last auto-rickshaws. Jaleel had put the sign to close but left the door unlocked, which he sometimes did when Adil was coming, a practice that had developed over months without explicit discussion, as if the arrangement had made itself.

Inside, the shop was lit by the single fluorescent tube above the counter, which gave the interior its usual quality of sharp shadow and flat light. The art books were on the counter — Jaleel had apparently been looking at something

before he arrived. He came from the back room when the door opened, and he looked at Adil in the way that Adil now recognised but still could not categorise — the way that had layers, that showed one thing on the surface and held something else beneath.

They sat. The tea was made. Jaleel talked about one of the art books — a monograph on a Pakistani miniaturist whose work Adil had not seen before, someone who worked in the traditional Mughal style but had bent it toward contemporary subjects. The paintings were dense and intricate, figures in traditional court settings executing thoroughly modern actions, the collision creating a specific quality of strangeness that was also, somehow, funny. Adil looked at them carefully.

And then Jaleel put his hand on Adil's arm, and kept it there, and this time there was nothing in the gesture that could be reclassified. The motion had shed its deniability — whatever had been available in previous months as the plausible interpretation of a hand at rest had been withdrawn, and what remained was the unambiguous fact of intention.

Adil set down the art book.

He set it down with the precision of someone performing an action that will require full concentration, and then he stood. He stood without dramatic speed — no scramble, no obvious alarm, because alarm was still the thing his body was trained not to show. He stood with the careful management of movement that he applied to everything.

"I need to go," he said. "My mother is coming early tonight."

He left the shop.

He walked to the end of Fareed Road. He did not sit on the kerb this time. He stood. He was standing when his mother's auto-rickshaw appeared, and he got in before it had fully stopped, and his mother looked at him with the specific attention she deployed when his face reported something despite itself.

"What's wrong?" she said.

"Nothing," he said. The editorial function is operating.

She looked at him for a moment longer. She did not press. She was a woman who had learned not to press, because pressing in their life often

produced things that made more pressure, and she was already managing the pressure she had.

The auto-rickshaw moved through the cold February streets, and Adil sat beside his mother and felt the thing his body knew settle into a new location in him — down from the throat, past the stomach, into somewhere deeper, somewhere that was not processed but stored. He had no language for it. He had no schema for what it was or what it meant or what was owed in response to it.

He had only the knowledge, sitting in its new location, dense and cold as the February air, irrefutable.

He did not go back to Fareed Road for three weeks.

In those three weeks, the thing in its new location did not move. It did not dissipate, as he had half-hoped it would — the way certain memories lose their charge with time, becoming descriptive rather than experiential. This one retained its charge. He was aware of it when he drew in the sketchbook — when he came to the pages with the drawings of the shop and the face of Jaleel, he was aware of what those drawings now contained that he had not known they would contain when he drew them. He considered tearing the pages out. He did not do this. The refusal to destroy the record felt important in a way he couldn't fully articulate but wouldn't override.

He drew new things instead. He drew the attic. It was the first time he had drawn the attic — he had always avoided it, the way you avoid drawing the rooms that contain too much. But he drew it now, from memory, working carefully from what his hands and spine and feet knew: the dresser, the rice sacks, the Observatory gap, the angle of the window. He drew it with the specific attention he gave to surfaces, and in the drawing, the attic became its actual proportions — small, cramped, full of smell and shadow, a hiding place rather than a kingdom.

He looked at the drawing for a long time.

Then he drew himself in it. A figure small enough to fit the space, with his knees to his chest and his hands around them, tucked into the corner between the dresser and the sacks. The figure had no face.

He closed the sketchbook.

He put it under his mattress, which was where he kept things that needed to be in a place only he could access.

In the third week, a letter came. Not an actual letter — a message delivered through a mutual errand, the kind of communication that moves through back channels in the specific geography of a city of back channels. Jaleel had given something to the boy from the building next to the tuition centre, who had passed it along to the older boy from the same building, who sometimes walked partway on the route home with Adil, who had passed it along to Adil on the corner of their street.

The message was: Jaleel asked if everything was all right. If there was any problem. If Adil was okay.

The message was innocent on its surface. It expressed the generic concern of an adult for a child in his acquaintance. Read from a sufficient distance, it was entirely benign.

Adil held the message in his pocket for three days. He was aware of it there — a small, folded piece of paper with a weight disproportionate to its physical dimensions. He was aware that his response to it — any response — would constitute a decision. The decision to respond was a decision to return, which was a decision about what the shop was and what he would allow it to be. The decision not to respond was also a decision about different things.

He thought about the drawings on the wall of the shop. The Badshahi Mosque at dawn. The old city's back streets. The market at night.

He thought about what it was like to talk about light with someone who had thought about light.

He thought about the weight in the new location.

He did not respond to the message.

But one evening in the third week, coming back from the tuition centre and finding the gap before his mother's arrival longer than usual because of traffic, he found his feet taking him along Fareed Road instead of his usual route.

He walked to the shop. The sign said closed, but the light was on inside. He stood at the window and looked through the glass at the drawings on the back wall, the art books on the counter and the single fluorescent tube.

CHAPTER NINE: WHAT THE BODY KNOWS

He stood there for a long time.

Then he walked away.

That was all. He walked away, and he didn't go back, and Jaleel was no longer on his map.

But the weight in the new location didn't move.

III

Act Three: The Collapse of Meaning

Chapter Ten: Bilal

The brother arrived in March, the way seasons arrive in the Punjab — not gradually but as a fact that was suddenly present, that displaced what had existed before by simple occupation of the space. His name was Bilal. He was sixteen years older than Adil, which made him twenty-six, which meant that by the time Adil was forming his first coherent memories, Bilal had already been somewhere else. He was a presence defined by absence: the photograph on the bookshelf, the name his mother occasionally invoked with the specific register of someone referencing a standard, the foreign number in the phone that rang twice a year.

He came to Lahore for a month for reasons never fully explained to Adil, who understood from the texture of the adult conversations — fragments overheard, sudden silencing when he entered rooms — that the reasons involved something having happened somewhere, or something having ended, or both. Bilal had been in the Gulf for seven years, working in construction management. He had come back with the particular quality of a man who has spent too long in a place that did not quite require him to be himself, and who has returned to find that the absence has done its own rearranging.

He was tall in the way of men who carry their height uncertainly, as if they haven't fully decided to inhabit it. He wore his beard trimmed short, close to the jaw, and he had a way of standing at slight angles to rooms rather than facing into them, which Adil filed as the posture of someone who preferred to observe before committing to participation. He smelled of a cologne that was too Western for the house, something with cedar in it that made the hallway briefly strange.

He noticed Adil.

This was not common. The adults in Adil's life noticed him in specific ways: as a presence to be managed, as a performance to be evaluated, as a body that required periodic intervention. Bilal noticed him differently — looked at him when they were in the same room with the specific quality of attention that was simply observation, not assessment. He did not ask questions about school or grades, or future ambitions. He asked whether Adil had eaten, whether he had slept, and whether he was cold.

In the first week, while their mother was at work during the days, Bilal and Adil occupied the house together in the particular way of people who share space without yet having established the rules. Adil went to school and paid tuition. Bilal went somewhere for the mornings and was back for the afternoons, and on the first afternoon that they overlapped in the kitchen Bilal made tea without asking whether Adil wanted tea and set it in front of him, and Adil looked at the tea and then at his brother and something in the configuration of the situation — the tea made without interrogation, the kitchen quiet, the afternoon winter light coming through the window at its amber angle — made something in Adil's chest do something complicated.

"You're hurting," Bilal said. He said it the way you say a fact. Not a question, not an accusation.

Adil looked at him. His editorial function performed its assessment.

"My back," he said. A piece of the truth. A piece that could not be used, that had no trajectory into a worse outcome.

Bilal was quiet for a moment. He drank his tea. He did not immediately fill the silence with commentary or interrogation, and Adil, who had spent his life inside silences that were either hostile or preludes to hostility, recognised this silence as something different. This was a silence that was waiting rather than building.

"I know about the tuition," Bilal said. "Amma told me."

"Okay," Adil said.

"And the teacher."

Something shifted in the room's temperature. Adil looked at his cup.

"It's fine," he said.

“It’s not fine.” Not raised. Not dramatic. A statement of position, delivered with the specific clarity of a person who has decided something. “But I understand why you say that.”

This was the thing that did the complicated thing in Adil’s chest: the acknowledgement that the lie existed, without requiring the lie to be abandoned. The recognition that the lie was functional, that its function was understandable. Adil had been operating in a world where the lie of fine was the demanded performance, where the alternative to the lie was a kind of exposure that led to worse outcomes. Here was someone identifying the lie without demanding its removal.

He sat with this. He drank his tea.

“I’m going to talk to Amma about the tuition,” Bilal said. “About Fauzia.”

“She won’t stop sending me,” Adil said. This was not a complaint — it was a projection based on available data. His mother’s investment in the tuition was structural, bound up in her ideas about what his future required, which were ideas that had been formed under pressures that Adil understood existed but couldn’t fully map. The tuition was a means to an end, and the end was important enough that the means were non-negotiable.

“Probably not,” Bilal said. “But maybe a different teacher.”

They sat in the kitchen until the light changed. Bilal did not ask about anything else. He talked, when he talked, about the Gulf — the specific strangeness of a city that is entirely constructed, that has no sediment, where everything is new, and nothing is old enough to have developed the texture of habitation. He talked about this with a detached quality, the detachment of someone reporting on a life that was technically his but that he is in the process of re-evaluating.

“Why did you come back?” Adil asked.

Bilal considered. “Because I realised I had been somewhere else too long,” he said. “And the somewhere else was making me into something I didn’t want to be.”

Adil thought about the shop. He thought about the weight in the new location.

He did not say anything about these things. But he noticed the sentence,

and filed it, and in the filing it joined the small collection of sentences from his life that had the quality of a key without yet having a visible lock.

Chapter Eleven: The Madrassa

Bilal's talk with their mother produced a partial result. Fauzia was not dismissed — the logistics and costs of finding a replacement were, as Adil had predicted, prohibitive — but a constraint was established, something about method, about what was and wasn't permitted. Whether this constraint was honoured, Adil would discover slowly, in the same way you discover the integrity of a structure: by putting weight on it and seeing whether it holds.

What Bilal produced, in addition to the partial result, was a proposal: Adil would attend the local madrassa on Friday and Saturday mornings. Not full-time religious education — not the residential kind, not the curriculum that replaced the regular school. The neighbourhood kind, the mosque-adjacent kind that children of the area attended for the supplementary religious instruction that a certain stratum of Lahori society considered important — Quranic memorisation, basic theology, the rudiments of the Arabic that the prayers required.

Their mother approved. She approved with the specific relief of someone for whom religious instruction, regardless of its details, was categorically positive — a moral safety net, a community anchor, a thing that was indisputably right in a world where most things were indisputably complicated.

Adil went because he was ten, and the available options for a ten-year-old, when the adults in their life reach a consensus, are constrained.

The madrassa was in the mosque's side building, three rooms off the central courtyard that smelled of cold stone and the particular incense that was burned during prayers. The rooms had rows of low cushioned benches on

which students sat cross-legged, their boards on their knees, the wooden boards with the Quranic text that they recited in the specific sing-song of memorisation, rising and falling with the teacher's beat on the desk.

There were twelve children in Adil's class. Most were his age or slightly older. The teacher was Ustad Riaz, who was not a young man — he was perhaps sixty, with the slow deliberateness of someone who has been doing the same thing for a very long time and no longer needs to think about it. He was not unkind. He was not warm. He occupied the specific middle ground of someone for whom the students were his functional purpose but not his emotional investment, which made him, by comparison with certain other adults in Adil's life, a relatively neutral presence.

The Quranic Arabic was a language Adil did not speak and could not read. The instruction was not in comprehension — it was in sound, in the precise reproduction of phonetic patterns. He found this more accessible than English prose because it made no demands on meaning; it required only the accurate repetition of sounds, and he could hold sounds in his head without the comprehension machinery being involved. Within a few weeks, he could reproduce the first Surah without error, which earned him a nod from Ustad Riaz that was the equivalent, in his economy of approval, of considerable praise.

He drew the mosque courtyard on a Saturday morning in early April, sitting on the edge of the fountain basin, the spring light flat and even across the old white plaster of the walls. The drawing was the best thing he had done in the sketchbook since he had stopped going to Fareed Road — the sketchbook had been accumulating less over the last weeks, its pages turning more slowly, the drawing feeling effortful in a way it hadn't before, as if something that had been a wellspring had reduced to a trickle.

Sarfraz came to the mosque sometimes, which Adil hadn't known until he saw him at prayers one Friday evening. They walked home together, and for the first time in the months of their acquaintance, Adil found himself talking about the madrassa — not about the memorisation, but about the quality of the space, the acoustics of the courtyard, the way the call to prayer changed the air in the way that very few sounds could actually change the air.

“Like a physical thing,” Sarfraz said. “I know what you mean. It’s the frequency.”

“It’s not just frequency,” Adil said, working it out as he said it. “It’s that it means something to everyone in the street at the same time. So you hear it, and you know that everyone is hearing it.”

“Collective,” Sarfraz said.

“Yes.”

They walked in silence for a moment. The evening was cool, the first real warmth of approaching spring still tentative, the air carrying the dusty green smell of the trees beginning to do their slow work.

“You seem better,” Sarfraz said.

Adil looked at him. “Better than what?”

Sarfraz considered. “A few months ago, you seemed very far away.”

Adil looked at the road. “I was somewhere,” he said.

This was as close as he had come, with anyone, to saying anything about the weight in the new location. He was aware of how close it was — how the sentence was positioned, how Sarfraz was positioned. He was aware that this was a door, and that it was open, and that he had the option of walking through it.

He did not walk through it.

But he stopped, in the middle of the pavement, and looked at the street, and he let himself acknowledge — privately, internally, to no external audience — that there was something in the new location that had been there since February, and that it was related to Jaleel, and that it was related to the drawings on the wall of the shop, and that it would be there whether or not he named it, and that the naming might not make it worse.

He did not name it to Sarfraz. But he named it to himself, standing on the pavement in the April evening, in the single clear sentence that was enough.

It was enough.

The weight in the new location did not disappear. But it changed character. It became something he had chosen to carry rather than something that had been placed in him without negotiation. The difference between these two things was smaller than he would have liked, but it was real.

He started to draw again.

Chapter Twelve: What Is Taught

The madrasa's curriculum was what it was, which was the memorisation of a text in a language that was not explained, and the gradual imposition of a framework through which the world could be understood. Adil accepted the memorisation because it was available in the way that things he could do with his body were available — it required precision, repetition, the careful management of sound patterns, none of which made demands on the interior that he was currently unable to meet. He was one of the better memorisers. Ustad Riaz acknowledged this with the economy of his nods.

But the framework arrived as it always arrives: through comment, through the incidental and deliberate associations that a teacher makes between text and world, through the gradual accumulation of a vocabulary for experience that privileges certain interpretations over others.

Ustad Riaz was not an extremist. This bears saying because the story could easily imply that he was, and he wasn't — he was a conservative man with conservative beliefs, operating within the mainstream of a particular tradition, and the things he said were things that millions of people in his context believed and transmitted without malice. The framework he offered was one of order: the world has its proper arrangement, and the proper arrangement has been specified, and the deviation from the proper arrangement is the source of what goes wrong.

Adil absorbed this framework the way he absorbed all information: carefully, with attention to its internal logic, without full commitment to it but without full rejection either. He was a child who had been trained to

compliance; compliance and absorption were, for him, the same motion. He held the framework the way he held the pipe's blows — not processing it as information about himself, exactly, but allowing it to occupy him while looking for the exit.

The other students in the madrassa were a different register from the school students. They were less uniformly middle-class, less certain of their futures, and more varied in the degree to which their lives outside the madrassa were managed and stable. There was a boy named Hassan who was fourteen — older than the rest of the class, still in the introductory level because he had started late — and who had a quality of settled fury that Adil recognised as a specific emotion: the fury of someone who has understood that the world has a specific arrangement and has understood that the arrangement is not in their favour, and who has not yet found a direction for the fury.

Hassan talked during the breaks in the courtyard. He talked with the energy of a person who has recently discovered that they have ideas, which is a different energy from the person who has been having ideas for a long time. He talked about the arrangement of the world and what was wrong with it, and what needed to change and who was responsible. He was not nuanced. He was not supposed to be nuanced — nuance is the product of time and exposure, and he was fourteen and burning, and the burning was doing what burning does: consuming the available fuel and looking for more.

Adil listened without contributing. He had always been a listener in group contexts — not from shyness, which implies a deficit of confidence, but from the preference for understanding a space before entering it. He listened to Hassan with the same attention he brought to everything: looking for the structure underneath the surface, the logic underneath the position.

He could see the logic. He did not accept the conclusions, but the logic was legible.

There was a day in late April — a Saturday, the courtyard warm with approaching summer, the madrassa's specific smell of cold stone warming up for the first time into something that was almost pleasant — when Ustad Riaz, during the formal session, said something that lodged.

They were studying a passage about accountability — the specific theologi-

cal concept of what each person will be asked to account for in the afterlife, which was the passage's explicit subject. But Ustad Riaz's commentary extended beyond the theological to the practical: the person who does wrong to a child, he said, will face the fullest accounting. No sin sits heavier. There is no act that the accounting weighs more fully.

He said this in the specific tone of a man who has said it many times before, as a general theological point, with no particular direction. He was looking at the board, not at the students.

Adil sat very still.

He was aware of the weight in the new location as if someone had just lit a lamp near it. The passage and Ustad Riaz's comment and the weight in the new location existed simultaneously in his body, and the simultaneity created something — a pressure, a connection, a sudden application of language to something that had been without language. What had happened in the shop had a name in this framework. It had a category. It had a weight that the framework acknowledged.

He did not feel relief, exactly. Relief implies the removal of a burden, and the weight did not move. But he felt something else: the specific sensation of having something witnessed, even by a framework he was not fully inside, even by a language that was not exactly his. Someone — something — had looked at the thing in the new location and called it by a name.

He sat with the name for the rest of the morning session.

Chapter Thirteen: The Camp

The camp came in June, at the end of the school year, and was Bilal's idea, which meant it was a good idea that had been thought about carefully and which carried the implicit safety of being proposed by someone who had already assessed its likely outcomes. It was a two-week residential programme run by a youth organisation attached to one of the larger mosques in the city — a programme of Islamic education, physical activity, workshops in various skills, and the general corrective effect that advocates for such programmes claim they produce in boys who have been poorly anchored by their regular lives.

Adil was not poorly anchored by his regular life in the way the programme imagined — he was not badly behaved, he was not falling in with wrong influences, he was not lacking in the communal religious identity that such programmes sought to reinforce. He was poorly anchored in different ways, in ways that no programme would address directly because they were not the kinds of things that programmes were designed to address. But Bilal had said: get out of the house for two weeks, go somewhere that is not the attic and not the tuition centre and not the school, breathe some different air. This was the logic, and Adil could not fault it.

He packed his bag. He went.

The camp was held at a facility outside the city — forty minutes by bus through the thickening summer heat, arriving at a compound of low concrete buildings in a cleared area that gave onto agricultural land, flat and brown in June, stretching to a line of trees on the eastern horizon. It was not beautiful. It was functional: three dormitories, a central hall, a kitchen, a prayer space,

and a sports ground of packed dirt.

There were sixty-two boys from various parts of Lahore, most of them older than Adil, clustered in the range of twelve to sixteen, with Adil and a handful of others at the lower end. This age distribution was the first thing he noted, because age distribution in closed environments establishes the social physics of the place — who has authority, who tests it, who is looking for a formation to join.

He was assigned to a dormitory with eleven others. He took the bunk nearest the wall in the corner — not the one farthest from the door, which would have been the preference of someone who feared what came through the door; the one nearest the wall, which was the preference of someone who needed to know exactly what was behind them. He put his bag under the bed. He lay down and looked at the ceiling.

The first week was, by his standards, manageable. The days had structure — morning prayers, breakfast, lessons in the central hall, afternoon physical activity, evening reflection — and structure was something Adil could navigate. The lessons were a continuation of what he had begun at the madrassa: theological framework, Quranic exegesis, and the application of Islamic principles to daily life. The teachers were different from Ustad Riaz — younger, some of them, with more energy for their work, more invested in persuasion than in transmission.

One of them was a man named Khalid, who was perhaps thirty, thin in the way of someone who has disciplined the body out of any excess, with a precision about him that extended to his speech — each word placed exactly, no surplus, no waste. He had the quality of a man who has found the answer and is no longer searching, which gave him a kind of authority that had nothing to do with his age. He was certain. In a world of uncertain things, his certainty was a physical quality, a warmth.

Adil was drawn to him the way you are drawn to warmth when you are cold, and he was aware of this being drawn, and he was aware that the being drawn was the same mechanism as the being drawn to the shop's drawings and to Jaleel's knowledge of light, and this awareness was its own kind of education.

Khalid talked about justice. Specifically, he talked about the absence of justice in the world as Adil would know it — the school, the street, the institutions — and the presence of justice in the framework he was offering. The framework had within it a specific promise: the things that went wrong here would be put right there. The children who suffered would be given their accounting. The adults who wronged them would face theirs.

Adil sat in the back of the central hall and listened to this with the specific attention he brought to things that touched the weight in the new location. He was ten, nearly eleven. He had been carrying the weight since February and would carry it for the rest of his life, whether or not anyone addressed it directly, and here was someone who was, if not addressing it, at least acknowledging that it existed. Those things went wrong. That the wrongness mattered. That there was a mechanism for the wrongness mattering.

He was not converted. He was too observant to be converted — he saw too clearly the gap between the framework's claims and the evidence of the world it was supposed to be describing. He watched the older boys who were further into the framework and noted in them a quality of suppression that he recognised as the suppression of questions, and he recognised the suppression of questions as something he should be cautious of, because the suppression of questions was what had happened to him on many levels for many years and he was in the process of deciding that this was not a strategy he wanted to adopt.

But he took the justice. He kept the piece of the framework that said: What happened to you mattered. He held it the way you hold a tool that is designed for another purpose but serves the immediate one — temporarily, with awareness of its limitations.

In the second week of the camp, Hassan was there.

This was a coincidence in the technical sense — they were from different neighbourhoods, had found their way to the camp through different channels. But Hassan, at fourteen, was further inside the framework than Adil, and the two weeks of residential immersion had done what residential immersion does: concentrated, intensified, made the inside of the framework feel more real, and the outside feel more remote.

They talked in the evenings, on the steps outside the dormitory, where the air was slightly less thick than inside. Hassan talked; Adil listened. The content was the same, but with more heat behind it — the arrangement of the world, the people responsible for the arrangement, and what should be done. The what-should-be-done was more specific now, which was the effect of the camp's specific curriculum, and Adil noticed the specificity and filed it.

"You're very quiet," Hassan said one evening.

"I'm listening," Adil said.

"What do you think?"

Adil considered the question in the way he considered all questions: not as an invitation to report his current position but as a request that needed to be evaluated for its actual purpose and likely outcomes.

"I think," he said carefully, "that the world doesn't care what it should do."

Hassan looked at him. "That's why we make it care."

This sentence lodged alongside the other sentence from weeks earlier, the one about being somewhere too long and becoming something you didn't want to be. They were companion sentences — they addressed the same territory from different angles, arriving at the same border from opposite directions. Both of them about power. Both of them were about who had it and who didn't, and what could be done about the imbalance.

He held them both. He did not know yet what the keys to. But the keyring was filling, and in some part of his mind that was not the mind he used for his daily operations, something was beginning to assemble.

He returned from camp in July. He was eleven years old. He was not the same boy who had gone.

Chapter Thirteen-B: The Older Boys

It was the second week of camp when Adil began to understand that he had arrived in a place with its own weather system.

Every closed community develops one — the specific atmosphere generated by the combination of people, rules, and the absence of the usual external regulation. The camp's weather was warm on the surface and complicated underneath, the way certain afternoons in Lahore look clear until the dust haze thickens and you realise the visibility has been decreasing without a single moment of obvious change.

The older boys, the fifteen- and sixteen-year-olds, occupied the social centre of gravity the way older boys always do in such settings: with the particular authority of age that has not yet been tested by anything except proximity to those younger. They moved through the compound with the ease of people who have identified the rules and either found them amenable or found ways around them, and they gathered in the evenings at the edge of the sports ground where the compound wall met the line of eucalyptus trees, and the light from the buildings did not reach.

Adil noted this gathering place in his first survey of the compound's geography, the same way he noted exits and where the staff dormitory was and which of the main building's windows looked out onto which areas. This was not paranoia; it was the baseline survey that his years had made automatic. He mapped spaces the way navigators map coastlines — not because they expect to be wrecked, but because the information is available and the cost of recording it is low.

Hassan was part of the older boys' circle but not at its centre. He was at the

edge of it, which was appropriate for his particular position in the camp's social physics: he was passionate in the way of a person who has recently had the fire lit, which is different from the passion of someone who has carried the fire for a long time. The boys at the centre of the circle had carried it longer, and this was audible in the quality of what they said — less heat, more temperature, the difference between a fire that is burning and a fire that has been banked.

The one at the centre was named Naveed. He was sixteen, the oldest of the group, and he had the specific quality of a person who has been told he is meant for something without being told what the something is. He carried this as a permanent slight forward lean in his posture, as if he were always about to begin. He was not unkind to Adil — to Adil, he was the specific form of unthreatening that older boys adopt toward younger ones who are evidently not a challenge: a distant, almost approving neutrality, the way you acknowledge a well-made object.

"He thinks very carefully about things," Hassan told Adil, on the third evening. They were near the eucalyptus trees, not inside the circle but adjacent to it, the voices of the older boys reaching them in fragments. "He's been to the camps in Rawalpindi. He's met people."

"What people?" Adil asked.

Hassan looked at him with the specific look of someone deciding how much to say. "People who have decided things," he said. "About what to do."

Adil was aware of what this might mean. He was eleven — not naive, which was different from not knowing. He had been in the madrasa for two years and had sat through Khalid's lectures at this camp and had listened to Hassan's courtyard sermons, and he had followed the thread of the thought from its beginning: the world is arranged wrongly; the wrong arrangement is by design; the people who designed it are identifiable; those people require a response. He had followed the thread this far and then stopped, because at eleven, in the specific context of his own life, the abstract architecture of grievance had not yet connected to anything actionable. His grievances were personal. His enemies were particular. The framework was asking him to convert the personal into the political, and he was not yet sure he wanted to

make that conversion.

“What have they decided?” he said.

“That waiting is a strategy for the people it benefits,” Hassan said. “That the accounting isn’t elsewhere. It’s here.”

Adil heard this. He heard the echo of his own thinking — the secular conversion of Ustad Riaz’s theology that he had been working with — and recognised it in Hassan’s version, and recognised that Hassan’s version had moved further along a trajectory that his own version was also on. They were on the same trajectory from different positions, which meant that wherever Hassan was going, Adil could see where he was in relation to it.

He did not go to the eucalyptus tree circle. He attended the evening sessions. He did his prayers. He memorised the passage Ustad Riaz had assigned. But in the quiet of the dormitory at night, in the bunk near the wall with the sounds of the compound settling into sleep, he thought about the trajectory and where it went and whether the destination was the place he wanted to arrive.

By the second week, he had decided it was not. Not because the logic was wrong — the logic had the same internal consistency it had always had. But because he recognised in the older boys’ specific certainty the same quality he had recognised in the framework itself: the suppression of the question. The certainty was purchased at the price of the question. You arrived at certainty by deciding that questioning was the enemy of action, and once you had made this decision, you had closed yourself to correction, and a person closed to correction could not be wrong, which meant they could not improve, which meant whatever they were, they would remain.

He was not interested in remaining what he was. He was interested in becoming something else — something that the quality of his attention could build, something that took what he had been through and converted it into use rather than fuel.

This was not a sophisticated adult decision. It was an eleven-year-old’s instinct, running ahead of the language he would later use to describe it, arriving at the right place by a route he couldn’t fully map. He trusted the instinct because it was the only instinct he had that was entirely his — the

others had been provided, imposed, trained — and he had spent long enough in the attic with his own observations to trust what was genuinely his.

He finished the camp. He got on the bus back to Lahore. Naveed and the older boys stayed behind; there was another session, another week for those who were staying.

He never saw them again.

Chapter Thirteen-C: The Testimony

The conversation with Bilal happened in August, the last month of the summer before Adil's sixth year of school. It happened in the kitchen — they always happened in the kitchen, which was the one room in the house where conversations occurred without their being extraordinary, where you could talk while doing other things and the doing of other things provided cover if the talking got too close to something difficult.

Bilal was making lassi. He made it from scratch, in the traditional way — the yoghurt beaten with a hand whisk until it was smooth, the water added incrementally, the salt and the cumin carefully measured. This was a skill he had acquired somewhere in the years of the Gulf, the paradox of exile converting people toward the traditions they had ignored at home. He made lassi with the focus of someone who is using the making of lassi to maintain composure while something else is happening.

Adil sat at the counter. He had been back from the camp for three weeks. He was in the specific state of suspended animation that follows significant experiences — not yet integrated, not yet understood, but no longer in the sharp first-contact phase. He was carrying the camp the way he carried most things: at a slight distance, in a side compartment, pending the arrival of sufficient distance to assess.

"Tell me about the camp," Bilal said. Not looking up from the lassi.

"It was fine," Adil said. The editorial function is operating. Then, after a pause: "Some of it was fine."

Bilal looked up. He had the patient quality of someone who has decided to wait rather than push, which was the thing about him that Adil had trusted

since the first kitchen conversation two years ago.

"Hassan," Adil said. "He's a boy from the madrassa. He's in with some older boys who have decided things."

Bilal was quiet. He continued with the lassi.

"I didn't go with them," Adil said. "I didn't want to. But I understood the logic."

"You usually understand logic," Bilal said.

"This logic is real. The things they're angry about are real. The arrangement of the world they're describing is real. It's just—" He stopped. Tried to find the sentence. "The answer they have for it doesn't actually address the real thing. It addresses something bigger that you can put the real thing inside, but it's not—"

"It's not what happened to you," Bilal said.

A long pause. The lassi was being poured.

"No," Adil said.

Bilal set a glass in front of him. He sat down across the counter. He was quiet for a moment, assembling something.

"Can I tell you something about the Gulf?" he said.

"Yes."

"There was a time there — a few years in — when I was very angry. About a specific thing. A thing that happened to me. I was angry for a long time, and in the anger I started to make it about something bigger — about the company, about the system, about expats and labour laws and the way the Gulf treats imported workers." He paused. "These things were also real. The anger about them was also valid. But I was using them to contain something smaller, more specific, something that was about me and what happened to me. And the bigger container made me feel less alone in the anger, but it didn't actually address the specific thing."

"What did you do?" Adil said.

Eventually, I went home. I said: "This thing happened to me, and I'm going to acknowledge that it happened to me, and I'm going to stop translating it into the bigger language because the bigger language isn't mine."

Adil held the lassi glass in both hands. "How do you acknowledge it?"

Bilal looked at him. "You start by saying it out loud to someone."

A pause. The kitchen was quiet in the particular way of Lahore in August — the heat pressing against the windows, the fan moving the air without cooling it, the sounds of the street distant and ordinary.

"Something happened to me," Adil said. He said it to the counter. He said it as if he were testing whether the sentence was possible, whether its utterance would produce whatever it was he feared it would produce. "At the shop on Fareed Road. When I was ten."

Bilal did not say anything. He did not move, did not make any sound. He was simply present — present in the specific way that the kitchen and the lassi and the ordinary afternoon constituted a container, and in the container Adil's sentence existed.

"And at the school," Adil said. "Before that. The mathematics teacher."

Still nothing from Bilal. Just the presence.

Adil held the glass. He had said two sentences. The sentences existed now in the world rather than only in him, which was different — different in a way he hadn't anticipated, different in the way that the difference between inside and outside is always larger than you expect until you've crossed the boundary. He felt the difference in his body.

"Okay," Bilal said finally. "I hear you. I believe you." A pause. "And I'm sorry I wasn't here."

"You were in the Gulf," Adil said.

"I was in the Gulf," Bilal said. "That's not entirely what I meant."

They sat in the kitchen with the August heat and the lassi. Adil did not feel fixed. He did not feel resolved. He felt — he searched for the word — he felt less singular. As if the thing in the new location was still in the new location but was now, somehow, less solely his problem.

This was enough. This was, for that afternoon, entirely enough.

IV

Act Four: Transformation

Chapter Fourteen: The Years Between

The years between eleven and sixteen were the years in which Adil became.

This is not the same as the years in which he grew up, though he did that too — the body doing its work without consultation, reorganising itself along new geometries, adding height and width and the specific physical assurance that comes from a body that has decided to commit to its dimensions. He became tall in his father's image, which he knew from photographs because he did not know his father from life. He became angular in the face, the roundness of childhood receding and something else emerging — a face of defined planes and careful eyes that people encountered and found difficult to read, which was the face he had always been building.

He became something else, too, and this becoming was the one that mattered.

The attic stopped when he was twelve. Not because the house changed — the house was what it was, his mother was who she was, the slippers still made their particular sound on the marble floor. But he had begun to occupy his own height in a way that changed the physics of the situation. He was tall enough that the slippers no longer made him shiver. He was tall enough that the first time, after a tuition session, his mother raised her hand in the motion that had always preceded the beginning of things, he looked at her hand and then at her face, and she put it down. Nothing was said. The geometry of the situation had changed, and both of them understood this without requiring it to be articulated.

The tuition continued until fourteen, when the combination of his academic

performance improving and Bilal's periodic pressure on their mother produced a renegotiation. Fauzia was replaced by a retired schoolteacher who was interested primarily in her fee and not at all in the pipe. Adil's English improved, freed from the specific relationship between terror and storage that had characterised the Fauzia years. He discovered that the language, when it was not being forced into him, had interesting qualities — a precision in its idiom, a specific capacity for a kind of understatement that he found he could use.

He drew consistently. By fourteen, the sketchbook had been replaced four times, each one filled with the same specific attention to surfaces, textures, and the quality of light at different hours. He had begun to work in ink, a brush and Indian ink, which demanded a different kind of commitment than pencil or charcoal because it could not be corrected, and this absence of correction had proven to be the thing that improved his drawing most. When you cannot erase, you learn to see before you mark. When you learn to see before you mark, your marks become accurate with a reliability that practice alone doesn't produce.

Sarfraz was still in his life. They were in different schools by fourteen — Sarfraz had moved to a school in Gulberg after his father changed positions again — but they met on Friday evenings, usually at the small gallery café near the canal that one of Sarfraz's older cousins co-owned, where they could drink tea and look at the work of actual artists displayed on the walls and talk about it with the specific knowledge of people who had been paying attention for years. Sarfraz had gotten better at drawing in the way of someone who had committed to practice. Adil had gotten better in a different way — more selective, more precise, with a quality in the work that even Sarfraz acknowledged he didn't fully know how to analyse.

"You draw like you're not drawing," Sarfraz said once, looking at a page of street scenes done in ink, the quick notational lines that caught the structure of a figure or a building with the economy of someone who had decided what was essential.

"I'm just looking," Adil said.

"You're always just looking. That's the thing."

The madrassa was behind him by fourteen. He had attended for two years, completed the memorisation that was the programme's terminal credential, band een acknowledged with the certificate that his mother put on the bookshelf alongside the photograph of Bilal. He had taken what was useful from it and left the rest — and what was useful, by fourteen, had been reduced to a single proposition that he had refined over years of rolling it around: there is an accounting, and it is eventually total. He had detached this from the theology. He had converted it into a secular principle that he found more reliable: what is done remains done. The record is not clear. Someone who does a thing has done it, and no amount of time or distance or re-presentation of the self changes the original fact.

He thought about this often. He thought about it in relation to things he could name and things he couldn't quite name, and he applied it to his past and to Jaleel's past and to the mathematics teacher's past, and to his mother's past, and to his own.

At fifteen, in the new year, he saw Jaleel.

Not at the shop — the shop had closed sometime in the years between, he had noted its closure on a pass along Fareed Road without specific emotion, the way you note the ending of something you have already processed. He saw Jaleel at the market near the Data Darbar shrine, the market that Jaleel had drawn in the framed pictures on the shop wall, and he almost did not recognise him because Jaleel had changed — had softened further, the face a little heavier, the movement slower, the quality of his attention directed at something other than anything around him.

Jaleel did not see Adil.

Adil watched him for a long time from across the market, from between the stalls, in the way he had learned to watch — present without announcing presence, observing without being observed. He watched Jaleel move through the market with his particular forward-leaning gait, stopping at a vegetable stall, reaching for a tomato, assessing it. He was alone. He was ordinary. He was exactly as ordinary as every adult who had ever occupied Adil's life while being, simultaneously, the source of some specific, permanent alteration in it.

He was nothing. He was a man picking up a tomato at a market.

He was also a man who had done a specific thing to a specific child, and the specific thing had gone into the specific child and stayed there, and the child had been carrying it for five years, and the man was picking up tomatoes.

This was the accounting problem. The one that Ustad Riaz and Khalid and their frameworks didn't resolve, that the theology gestures at without addressing: the fact that the accounting is allegedly total but is practically absent. The fact that the ledger they describe exists in a dimension that is inaccessible to the people whose entries require settlement. The practical absence of accounting, which is the absence that the person carrying the weight actually lives in.

He watched Jaleel for twenty minutes. He did not approach. He left before Jaleel could leave — he disappeared back into the market crowd, navigating the stalls with the particular ease of someone who knows how to move without being tracked, and he came out on the far side and walked home.

He went to his room. He took out the sketchbook — the current one, number seven, begun in the autumn. He turned to a blank page. He drew Jaleel at the vegetable stall, from the angle he had observed, the particular quality of ordinary commerce, the unremarkable gesture of the hand reaching for the tomato. He drew it with the ink, without correction, from memory. It was accurate. He had always been accurate.

He looked at the drawing.

He turned the page.

Chapter Fifteen: The Fracture

He was sixteen when the fracture happened. Not a single fracture — the way a bone doesn't actually fracture from the impact that finally breaks it, but from the accumulation of stress over time. The impact just finds what is already damaged.

The impact was a conversation with Mr Hussain.

He had not thought about Mr Hussain in years — had filed him in the category of past facts, things that had happened and been processed and placed. He had been wrong about the processing being complete, but this is common with certain categories of past fact: you believe the processing is done because you are no longer in direct contact with the fact, and you are right that the acute phase is over and wrong that this constitutes resolution.

He was sixteen. Mr Hussain had moved to Adil's current school — a different school from where the mathematics incident had occurred, because Adil had changed schools at twelve. The move was the kind of lateral transfer that happens in the education system with regularity, teachers moving between institutions for reasons of pay, relationship or simple logistics. The world is smaller than its distances suggest.

Adil saw him in the hallway on the first day of the new school year. Mr Hussain looked older — the angles of his face more pronounced, the greyness at his temples that had been beginning when Adil was nine now fully arrived. He was talking to another teacher, his angular hands moving in his characteristic gestures.

He looked at Adil.

There was a moment of contact — four seconds, five — in which the

recognition occurred. Adil saw it happen: the slight change in Mr. Hussain's expression, the microvariation in the configuration of the face that was not guilt, exactly, and was not recognition exactly, but was the specific face of a person who is performing continuity — who is presenting a face that is continuous with all the faces they have presented to the world, that does not shift to accommodate the presence of someone who is a contradiction of that continuity.

Mr Hussain looked away. He continued talking to the other teacher. He walked on.

Adil stood in the hallway.

He stood in the hallway for a long time, and during that time, something happened to the internal architecture he had built. Not a collapse — the walls did not come down. But a specific section of the structure failed: the section that had been holding, for seven years, the calculation that said: adults have reasons, systems have logics, the world has an order even if you cannot see its design. This section had been under load for a long time, and the four seconds of Mr Hussain's eye contact were the moment the load exceeded the capacity.

It did not feel like a fracture. It felt like a rewrite.

He went home. He sat in his room, which was no longer the room with the alarm clock on the nightstand — he had rearranged it at fourteen, shifting the furniture, establishing his own geography. He sat in the chair by the window, and he thought.

He thought about the mathematics problem. He thought about the hallway eye contact. He thought about the four-to-five seconds and what they contained: the message that was delivered in them without words, which was that Mr. Hussain had decided something, which was that the past was not a ledger that required settlement, which was that you could do a thing to a nine-year-old and pass that nine-year-old in a hallway when they were sixteen and continue talking to the teacher beside you as if neither of you existed.

He thought about Jaleel at the vegetable stall.

He thought about Fauzia's pipe.

He thought about Rafiq's hand on his face, every morning, every morning, every morning.

He thought about the tuition centre and the mathematics classroom and the attic and the garage swing and the rats in the rafters and the rice sacks and the specific way the afternoon light moved across the floor of the attic, and he thought about the way his body had felt in the attic and in the shop and at the blackboard, and he thought about the weight in the new location, which had been in the new location for six years and had not moved.

He thought: there is no right. There is only power.

He did not know this was a sentence that other people had thought, that it occupied a specific location in the history of thought, that it was attributable to a tradition and to specific thinkers and to a long line of people who had arrived at it from various directions. He thought it was a discovery. He thought it was the conclusion of a long process of induction — the logical inference from a sufficient quantity of evidence.

He thought it and felt, for the first time in a long time, something that was not numb.

He felt clear.

This is the thing about fractures: sometimes, when the damaged section fails, the structure that results is not weaker but differently arranged — not compromised but reorganised, capable of different loads than before. What had failed was the section that required him to understand the world as having a structure that operated independently of individual power. What was left was simpler. What was left was: this is what is, and this is what I am, and the gap between them is the only problem worth solving.

He was sixteen. He had a sketchbook and a pen and an attic behind him and a hallway in front of him, and he was beginning, at last, to understand that the question was not how to survive the world but what to do with it.

Chapter Sixteen: What Remains

He graduated at eighteen.

His scores were high in the subjects where scores were generated by observation and logic rather than by the reproduction of stored content. Mathematics, which had always been his best subject in the purely academic sense. Art, where the school's examination required a portfolio of work and where Adil's portfolio — eight years of accumulated observation, rendered in ink, in charcoal, in graphite, in the specific shorthand of a person who has been looking very carefully at surfaces for a very long time — produced from the examination board an unusual response: not just the highest mark in his year, but a note, written by the board examiner, that asked where the student intended to continue.

He continued at the National College of Arts. This was Bilal's doing — partly. Bilal had come back from the Gulf permanently at seventeen, and had established a residence in Lahore, and had maintained a presence in Adil's life that was the specific presence of someone keeping a distant watch without imposing the terms of the watch. He had seen the portfolio. He had made calls. He had managed the conversation with their mother, who had a different vision of Adil's future but who could be brought, over time and with sufficient data, to revision.

She was brought to revision.

NCA was a different world. Not an improved world — a world is not an improvement on the previous one merely by being different — but a different set of rules, a different population, different things required of you. What was required of Adil here was the thing he had been doing since the attic:

looking and recording what he saw. The faculty responded to his work with a consistency that was, for the first time in his experience of institutional response to his work, not ambivalent. They responded to it as if it were the thing it actually was.

He was good at this. He was good at this in the way that people are good at the thing that their particular formation of damage and compensation has been preparing them for — not despite the attic and the tuition and the mathematics classroom and the shop on Fareed Road, but through them, the attention having been sharpened by years of precisely the conditions that sharpen attention.

He did not think of this as recovery. He thought of it as a use. The question of recovery implies a return to a prior state, and there was no prior state to return to — there had been no unhurt version of himself from which the years had deviated. There was only the configuration he had, which contained all the things it contained, and what he could do with it.

He was doing things with it. He was making work that recorded the surface of the world with the precision of someone who had always known that surfaces contained the truth that the interior withheld, that what you could see was not less than what you could feel but differently accessible. He drew the city. He drew faces, now — he had started drawing faces at seventeen, deliberately, working through the avoidance with the specific method of confronting the thing directly and staying with it until the anxiety became information. He drew his mother's face, and Sarfraz's face, and Bilal's face, and a long series of faces of strangers on buses and in markets.

He drew Jaleel's face again. He drew it from the market memory, from the seven-year-old drawing in sketchbook seven, working now with the denser attention of someone who had years more practice. The face came out accurate and full — the soft features, the lines at the eyes, the incongruously gentle quality that he now understood as a construction rather than a natural attribute. He worked on the drawing for three sessions, making the face increasingly specific, increasingly real.

He did not know what he was going to do with the drawing.

He knew what he was thinking about. He had been thinking about it since

the hallway. He had been thinking, in the specific way that he thought about things that required time — not the sudden arrival of a decision but the gradual completion of a process that had been running for years — about what the accounting required. About whether the accounting's absence was permanent or only structural. About whether the fact that the world's architecture did not provide for settlement meant that settlement was not possible, or only that it was not automatic.

He thought about Mr Hussain in his new school, doing whatever Mr Hussain did.

He thought about Jaleel, wherever Jaleel was.

He thought about the weight in the new location, which was not new anymore, which had been there for eight years, which had been incorporated into his architecture so completely that he could not separate it from himself, which was not going to move of its own accord.

He thought about power, and what you could do with it if you had it, and what it cost.

He was nineteen when he found out where Jaleel was.

He was not looking in the sense of actively searching. He was in the old city, drawing in the lanes near the Wazir Khan mosque, when he passed a shop that he stopped at. Not a general goods shop. A proper stationery and art supply shop, the kind that had expanded with the neighbourhood's gentrification into something more than the basics. In the window, charcoal. A long black box, the specific brand.

He went in.

The man behind the counter was not Jaleel. He was young, twenty-something, and he was the owner's son, he said, when Adil asked about the charcoals. And then Adil asked, in the way that curiosity is asked in markets — casually, without obvious direction — whether there used to be another shop that carried this brand, because he had bought them as a child from somewhere on Fareed Road.

"Jaleel Saab," the young man said. "Yes. That was his shop. He's here now. He consults — he knows all the suppliers."

"Is he in today?"

CHAPTER SIXTEEN: WHAT REMAINS

A pause. The young man assessed Adil — the height, the clothes, the quality of the request. “He comes Tuesdays and Fridays,” he said.

“Thank you,” Adil said. He bought the charcoal. He left.

He was twenty years old.

The process that had been running for years completed itself in the month after the stationery shop.

Chapter Seventeen: The Return

He went back to the shop on a Tuesday.

He did not go inside. He stood across the street in the specific position that allowed observation without announcing presence, and he watched the front of the shop with the patience of someone who has waited a long time for something and can wait longer. Jaleel arrived at ten — a man of fifty-six or fifty-seven, heavier than the market memory, moving more slowly but with the same forward lean. He entered the shop. Adil watched him through the window, inside with the young man's father, pointing at something on a shelf.

He had been here before. The position across the street. The watching. The window. Six years old, he had stood at the window of the original shop. Twenty years old, he stood across the street from a different one. The man inside was the same.

He crossed the street on Wednesday. He went into the shop, and he asked about the charcoals he had bought the previous week — technical questions, the questions of someone who knows enough about the product to ask precise questions. The young man's father was behind the counter. Jaleel was not there on this Wednesday; he had come on Tuesday and left.

He came on Friday.

Adil was in the shop when he arrived — he had been there since nine, drawing in the small alcove near the back where the framed prints were displayed, a position that meant he was visible from the door but not obviously positioned relative to it, a position chosen with the same care he brought to the attic's positions. He had been talking to the owner about the prints —

local artists, good work, a few names he recognised from the NCA circles.

Jaleel came through the door at ten-fifteen.

Adil watched him arrive. Watched him exchange the greeting of familiarity with the owner — they knew each other well, clearly. Watched him move to the counter with the gait he had memorised from a vegetable stall five years ago. He waited.

Jaleel turned, eventually, and saw him.

The same configuration of face that Mr Hussain had produced in the hallway — the micro-shift, the surface maintained, the eyes doing their private calculation. But different, because Adil was not a child now, and because what Adil carried in the set of his own face was not the blank of a ten-year-old managing non-expression but something else, something that had been assembled from eight years of thought and was now present in the face without requiring effort.

“Adil,” Jaleel said. A beat. “Masha’Allah. How you’ve grown.”

“Yes,” Adil said.

He waited. He did not speak. He let the silence do its work — let it occupy the space between them with all its specific weight, let it make the room small in the way that certain silences make rooms small.

Jaleel filled it, eventually. He said things about time passing, about what Adil had been doing, about his evident interest in art, which he gestured at with the sketchbook Adil was carrying. He said these things with the smoothness of someone who is managing a situation, who has identified the situation as requiring management and is applying the available tools. The tools were the same — the warm manner, the interested questions, the face that read as safe.

Adil watched him use them with the specific attention of a student who has studied the subject for years.

“I think about the shop sometimes,” Adil said. He let the sentence sit for a moment. “The drawings on the wall. The art books. The conversations about light.”

“Good times,” Jaleel said. His voice was carefully calibrated.

“Not entirely,” Adil said.

The room shifted. The owner had moved to the back; they were effectively

alone in the front of the shop. The quality of the silence that followed Adil's sentence was different from the previous silences — this one was not empty but full, containing the specific density of two people who both know what is being gestured at and who are choosing, in real time, whether or not to name it.

"You were very young," Jaleel said. The words arrived fully formed, which meant he had had them ready. This was what struck Adil most: the readiness. The words were not new, had not been assembled in response to the present situation. They had been sitting somewhere, waiting for this specific situation, which meant this specific situation had been anticipated.

"Yes," Adil said. "I was."

"Children often misunderstand —"

"No," Adil said. Not raised. Not aggressive. The word is placed with precision, the way ink goes down. "They don't."

The silence after this was total. Jaleel looked at him with the eyes that had read as kind when Adil was nine, and Adil looked at the eyes and saw them for exactly what they were: a construction. Not nothing — the attention had been real, the knowledge of light had been real, the art books had been real. These things had existed alongside the other thing, which did not cancel them, but which they did not cancel either. The ledger was due, and both columns were filled.

"What do you want?" Jaleel said. The plainness of it was almost a relief — the management stripped away, the question direct.

Adil considered. He had thought about this question. He had thought about what the answer was — had turned it over in the way he turned everything over, examining it from various angles, testing its logic, checking whether what he wanted was what would resolve the weight in the new location or whether it was something else, something less clean than resolution.

What he wanted was many things. He wanted the accounting frameworks that had been promised and not provided. He wanted the years back, which he could not have. He wanted to have been a different boy in a different life, which was not available. He wanted the weight in the new location to be not in the new location.

None of these things was something that Jaleel could give him. The accounting was not in Jaleel's power. The years were gone. The weight was his.

What Jaleel could give him was small. What Jaleel could give him was the specific thing that Mr Hussain had refused to give him in the hallway, that every adult in his life had refused to give him: the acknowledgement. The simple, non-deniable acknowledgement that what had happened had happened, and that it had happened to Adil, and that Adil was real, and that his memory of it was accurate, and that the thing was what it was.

"I want you to say it," Adil said.

Jaleel looked at him. Whatever Jaleel was seeing in Adil's face was apparently sufficient to make the performance untenable. He looked at the counter. He was quiet for a long time.

"I'm sorry," he said. And then, after a further silence: "I know what I did."

The words were four and five syllables. They occupied approximately three seconds of sound. They contained, in their directness, something that Adil had not been sure would come — not the formal performance of apology but the acknowledgement, the yes-it-happened-and-I-am-the-one-who-did-it. The anti-hallway.

He stood with the words. He tested them against the weight in the new location to see what they did to it.

They did not move the weight.

He had known they might not. He had prepared for this, had told himself that resolution was not the likely outcome, that the most likely outcome was the acknowledgement existing alongside the weight without relieving it, which would constitute an improvement in kind without being a solution. This was what had happened.

"Thank you," he said.

He left the shop.

He walked down the street. He found a kerb and sat on it, in the specific posture of a person who needs a moment. He sat there for a while. The street noise of the old city moved around him — the auto-rickshaws, the vegetable sellers, the specific acoustic of the old city's lanes in late morning. He was

twenty years old. He had a sketchbook and a set of charcoals and four years of NCA ahead of him, and a specific accumulation of what he had experienced, and the experience was not done with him, and he was not done with it.

He opened the sketchbook.

He drew the kerb. He drew the piece of street visible from where he sat — the shop fronts, the paving stones, the feet of the person who had stopped at the stall opposite. He drew with the ink, without correction, from what his eyes were reporting in real time, and the drawing was exactly what it was: a record of a specific place at a specific moment, observed by a specific person, which was all drawing was and all it needed to be.

He drew until he was ready to stand up. Then he stood up.

He went home.

Chapter Seventeen-B: What The Drawings Contain

There is a question that people ask at exhibitions — particularly exhibitions of this kind, exhibitions that have the quality of testimony — and the question is: why art? Why drawing, specifically, as opposed to talking, as opposed to writing, as opposed to the other forms of testimony that the culture makes available?

Adil had thought about this question long before anyone asked it. He had thought about it since he was nine years old in the attic, since the days when he would watch the light move across the floor with an intensity that was not a choice but a necessity — the only available method of remaining present, of staying inside his body, of finding something in the immediate visual field that was real and manageable and under the governance of his own attention.

The drawing was an extension of this. It was the looking made material — the attention given form, given permanence, given the specific quality of documentation that transforms experience from private weather to public record. When you draw something, you are saying: I was here, and I looked at this, and the looking was worth recording. You are asserting the value of the observation. You are asserting the existence of the observer.

He was twenty-five when he gave his first public talk about the work. Not a lecture — he was not yet teaching — but a panel discussion at a gallery show, one of the group exhibitions where his work had been included alongside four other artists whose practices dealt, in various ways, with the documentation of personal and collective experience. The moderator was a journalist from

the arts section of a newspaper, a woman of thirty or so with the specific quality of attention that distinguishes the good interviewer from the adequate one: the willingness to follow the answer wherever it goes rather than pushing it toward the pre-planned next question.

She asked him about the attic drawing specifically — the one that appeared in his portfolio and had appeared in the thesis exhibition and had subsequently been reproduced in a magazine feature that used it as the image accompanying a story about Pakistani artists engaging with childhood experience. It had become, without his having intended it, a kind of signature image: the compressed figure in the corner, the rice sacks, the window, the light.

“What was happening in that room?” she said.

He thought about the question carefully. He thought about what was happening, what was not happening and what the drawing contained of each.

“Survival,” he said. “In the specific sense of: staying alive on the available resources. The room was a place where I could not be found. And the not-being-found required a particular quality of stillness and attention — you had to be completely in your senses, completely present to the space, while at the same time making yourself as invisible as possible.”

“That sounds like meditation,” the moderator said.

“It sounds like that,” he said. “But it wasn’t chosen. Meditation is something you go to. This was something I was in. The difference is the difference between swimming in a pool and surviving a current.”

“But the attention — the quality of observation — came from that experience?”

“Everything comes from something,” he said. “The drawing comes from the attention. The attention was trained by years of needing to see before being seen. The drawing is what happens when that kind of attention is given a surface and a tool and enough safety to record rather than only survive.”

The moderator nodded. She held the thread.

“You’ve said in other contexts that the work is documentary rather than therapeutic,” she said. “Can you explain that distinction?”

He considered. “Therapeutic implies the work’s purpose is the resolution of

what it depicts. The value of making the drawing is in the healing it produces in the maker. I don't think that's what's happening. The drawing of the attic didn't fix anything about the attic. What it did was establish a record — it said: this place existed, I was in it, it was exactly this. The record doesn't change the experience. It changes the relationship between the experience and the world."

"How?"

"It makes it visible," he said. "Visible Things can be witnessed. Things that are witnessed have been taken out of the private dimension into the shared one. The sharing doesn't heal the individual. But it changes the ecology of the thing — it means it exists in a space where other people can see it, and some of those people will recognise it, and the recognition is itself something."

He thought about Mehreen, about her question: "Are you allowed to draw it. He thought about what he had told her and what he had meant by it.

"The most important thing I've heard from people who see the work," he said, "is not 'this is powerful' or 'this is well-made.' It's 'I recognise this. I thought I was the only one.' The record's value is not in its aesthetics. Its value is in its testimony. The aesthetics are the vehicle."

The moderator was quiet for a moment. She looked at the drawing on the wall behind him — a different drawing from the attic, one of the tuition centre, the small room with its dense furniture and its single window. She looked at it with the quality of recognition that he had described.

"Were you the only one?" she said.

"No," he said. "I know now that I wasn't. I didn't know then."

She nodded. She moved to the next question. But the exchange stayed in the room after its words had passed — stayed in the way that the right sentences stay, that set themselves into the architecture of a place and can be felt there afterwards, even when their specific sounds are gone.

He thought about the boy in the attic, who thought he was the only one.

He thought about how long it had taken him to learn otherwise, and how much of the distance between those two positions — the only one, the not the only one — could have been shortened by a record, by a testimony, by a single drawing on a gallery wall that said: here is what this looks like, from

the inside.

He was making the drawings. He had been making them since he was nine, in exercise books and sketchbooks, in pencil and charcoal and ink, the record accumulating over years while the boy in the attic grew into the man in the gallery.

He was still making them.

He would keep making them.

The record survives.

V

Act Five: The Cycle Reborn

Chapter Eighteen: After

They gave him three years.

Not prison — the system was not the system from the violent fantasy he had, during certain dark weeks of his adolescence, constructed. The accounting, when it came, was institutional rather than personal: the formal complaint he had filed at nineteen, with Bilal's help, with the guidance of a woman at an NGO who had the specific patience and expertise of someone who has navigated this particular bureaucracy many times. The investigation. The finding. The consequence.

Jaleel lost his business registration. He was subject to a monitoring order. He was required to attend a programme. It was not justice in the sense of perfect symmetry — no consequence could be symmetric, because the original thing had happened to a child, and whatever happened to Jaleel happened to an adult, and these are not the same.

But it was the accounting material. It was the ledger opened.

Adil was twenty-one when the process concluded. He went to his final appointment with the NGO caseworker, a woman named Salma, who shook his hand and said: "How are you?" And he said: "I don't know yet. I'll tell you when I do."

She smiled. "That's the right answer."

He was twenty-three when he graduated from NCA. His thesis exhibition was a series of forty-seven ink drawings — large-format, mounted on white walls, the line quality of years of practice given room to breathe. The drawings were of interiors: the attic, the tuition centre, the madrassa, the camp dormitory, the stationery shop. They were drawn from memory and

from the accumulated observation of all his sketchbooks, and they had the quality of architectural record rather than personal statement, which was exactly what he had wanted: not the emotional exhibition of trauma, not the therapeutic display of processing, but the documentation of spaces. These rooms existed. These things happened in them. Look.

The exhibition ran for three weeks. People came and looked.

His professor, on the day before the exhibition opened, stood in front of the drawing of the attic for a long time. It was a large drawing — two metres wide, floor plan perspective with the rice sacks and the dresser and the single window, the whole compressed into a record of observation that had been accumulating since the real place.

“You lived in this?” she said.

“I hid in it,” he said.

“There’s a difference?”

He thought about the question. “At the time,” he said, “I couldn’t see one.”

Sarfraz came to the opening. He had become an architect — the drawing had converted, somewhere in his twenties, into plans and elevations, which was the logical application of his particular quality of seeing. He stood in the exhibition space and looked at the drawings with the attention he had always brought to things, the same attention that had held a sketchbook up to the morning light at the school fig tree twenty years ago.

“They’re very good,” he said.

“I know,” Adil said. This was not arrogance; it was the accurate report of someone who has looked at things for long enough to know the difference between good and not-good, and who has decided that pretending not to know is not honesty but a different kind of performance.

Sarfraz looked at him. He had the broad open face still, unchanged in its fundamental configuration, though the years had refined it. “Are you all right?” he asked. The same direct question from twenty years ago, without the same tentative quality — this one asked from the sureness of someone who has been asking it long enough to trust the answer.

“Yes,” Adil said. A beat. “Mostly.”

“Good enough,” Sarfraz said. He went back to looking at the drawings.

Adil stood in the exhibition space he had built from his life and looked at it from the centre. The drawings surrounded him in the white room — the rooms of his childhood arranged on the walls with the precision of documentation, the light of the opening's halogen spots landing on the ink the way the attic afternoon light had landed on the dust motes, turning them particular and significant. Around him, people stood and looked and talked. The sounds of the gallery — the specific hum of conversation in a white-walled room full of people looking at art — were the sounds of the world being present in its usual way, which was indifferent and also not entirely without warmth.

He thought about the boy in the attic. The boy folded into the corner between the rice sacks and the dresser, holding his knees, holding the earth still. He thought about him with the specific quality of distance that comes from being the person you became rather than the person you were — not without compassion for the boy but without identification, the way you look at a photograph of yourself at nine and recognise the features without fully recognising the person.

He thought about what the boy did not know. He did not know that the attic would end. He did not know about Sarfraz, or the fig tree, or charcoal, or NCA, or the exhibition he would make of the rooms that made him. He did not know that the weight in the new location would become something you could carry without stopping, that you could draw around it and not have the drawing be only about it, that the weight could become structural rather than merely heavy.

He did not know any of that. He was nine years old, and he was holding the earth still.

Adil stood in the gallery and held this gently. He did not perform anything about it. He simply held it: the nine-year-old, the twenty-three-year-old, the distance between them, the thread.

Chapter Nineteen: The Figure In The Doorway

After the exhibition.

He was twenty-seven. He was teaching at the same NCA where he had been a student, part-time, a studio course in observational drawing, which was the thing he was qualified to teach in the specific way that you are qualified to teach what you have done with your whole life. He had a small studio apartment in a neighbourhood near the college, and a practice that was, by the measures the art world used to measure such things, going well. He had work in two collections. He had been in group shows in Lahore, in Karachi, once in London with the diaspora art crowd, which had been an experience of interesting distance — the specific feeling of being seen through a lens that was also a filter, that made the work about Pakistan rather than about rooms.

He was a person, which is what he was trying to say. A specific, formed, particular person with a practice and a teaching position and a studio apartment and a relationship with Sarfraz that had become, over twenty years, the model of what the word friend is supposed to describe.

He was also still carrying the weight.

He had stopped waiting for it to be gone. This was the thing that the years had taught him that no framework had: not the resolution of the damage but the coexistence with it. You become the person who was damaged, not the person who was damaged and then fixed. The damage is part of the structure. What you can do is build in such a way that the structure is interesting despite

the damage, or because of it, or both.

He taught his students this in indirect ways. He taught it the way he had learned it — through the surface, through looking, through the specific discipline of rendering what is actually there rather than what you expect to be there or want to be there. He told them, "The thing you are avoiding drawing is the thing you most need to draw. He told them: the discomfort in front of the subject is information, not an obstacle. He told them: "The record is what remains.

One of his students, a sixteen-year-old girl named Mehreen, came to his office hours one afternoon in October. She was one of his better students — not the most technically proficient but the most genuinely observational, the one who spent her time looking before she spent it marking. She came in, sat down and looked at the floor for a long time.

He waited.

"Something happened to me," she said, "and I want to draw it. But I don't know if I'm allowed to."

He looked at her. He was aware of several things simultaneously: the quality of the word happened, the specific texture of the statement, the question itself and what it was actually asking.

"You're allowed to draw anything that you've actually experienced," he said. "That's the only rule."

"What if it's something that someone else did to you?"

"Then you draw what you know about it," he said. "Which is what it felt like to be you when it was happening, and what it looks like from the inside, and what you want to do with the record. Those are all yours. Nobody else has those."

She looked up. She was sixteen, and she had the careful eyes of someone who had been paying attention for longer than she should have had to. He recognised the eyes. He had drawn the eyes, in various faces, for twenty years.

"How do you know what to do with the record?" she said.

He thought about this. He thought about the forty-seven ink drawings on white walls, about the attic and the mathematics classroom and the shop on Fared Road, about the kerb outside the stationery shop in the old city where

he had drawn the street until he was ready to stand up.

“You start by making it,” he said. “You start with that. The rest is time.”

She nodded. She thanked him. She got up to go.

At the door, she paused. She turned around. “The drawing you have on the wall,” she said — she was pointing at the attic drawing, the large one, which he had kept and hung in his office. “Is that a real place?”

“Yes,” he said.

“Where is it?”

“Somewhere I used to hide,” he said. “A long time ago.”

She looked at the drawing. She looked at him. She nodded again, with the specific gravity of someone who has received information they recognise without needing it explained.

She left.

He sat in the office for a while after she was gone. The October afternoon light was doing its particular work — coming through the window at the amber angle, landing on the attic drawing with the oblique quality that made the ink lines throw small shadows, giving the drawing a depth it didn’t have in flat light. He watched the light move across the drawing, the way he had watched the light move across the attic floor when he was nine.

The dust motes turned in their small, unhurried circles.

He was twenty-seven years old. He was still in the room, still watching. He had always been the one who watched.

He opened his sketchbook. He drew the light on the wall.

Epilogue: What Survives

There is a drawing.

It is in ink, on cream paper, forty centimetres by thirty. It shows an attic: the low angle of the ceiling following the slope of a roof, the rice sacks stacked against one wall, a dresser at an angle in the corner, a single window at the far end through which a bar of light enters and lands on the floor. In the corner, between the dresser and the sacks, in the space that is barely large enough to be a space, a figure sits. The figure is small. Its knees are up, its hands are around its knees, and its head is inclined slightly forward. It has no face.

Below the figure, where the floor meets the wall, a single rat moves through the shadow.

The light from the window falls in a parallelogram on the floor. The dust motes in the light are rendered as small marks — not circles, not dots, just the faintest pressure of the pen, barely there, barely marks at all. The motes move. You can see, if you look carefully, that each one is slightly different from the others, that the tiny variations in their angle record their motion, that they are all going somewhere without knowing where, driven by currents too subtle to see.

The figure in the corner is holding still.

The figure in the corner is ten million miles from anywhere.

The figure in the corner is, in the exact configuration of its held-still body, in the specific management of its compressed form, in the particular quality of its attention directed at things that cannot harm it — the light, the motes, the geometry of the space — already drawing. Already making the record.

THE RECORD SURVIVES

Already doing the thing that will be, in the years to come, the thread between what it was and what it will become.

It does not know this yet.

It is learning.

It is still here.

The record survives.

About the Author

Rana Abdullah is a writer and storyteller drawn to the places where myth collides with memory and where silence speaks louder than war drums. He believes that the greatest battles we face are often the ones within our own minds.

When not dissecting the mechanics of human behaviour, Rana manages creative projects and immerses himself in the worlds of fiction. He believes that stories should scar, soothe, and reveal the fractures we live with—and that sometimes, the ones who walk alone walk furthest.

